

EXPLORING EMPLOYEE PERCEPTIONS OF PERSONAL INITIATIVE AND ITS IMPACT ON CAREER ACHIEVEMENT

by

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(Under the Direction of Roger B. Hill)

ABSTRACT

Essential skills will become even more critical post-COVID-19. Initiative is one of the top essential skills sought by employers, yet it is also one of the top essential skills that new entrants lack entering the workforce. In this era of rapid change and disruption, it is necessary for youth and students not only to arrive in the workforce aware of this essential skill, but also to possess it within their skill set as a potential employee. However, there is limited research on how personal initiative develops before adulthood. Thus, opportunities to be aware of and develop this essential skill present challenges for young people entering the workforce. This research explored how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. This basic interpretive qualitative study was conducted at a higher education institution in the Southeastern U.S. using a purposefully selected sample, with criterion sampling as the specific strategy. Data were collected from eight participants through semi-structured interviews using the University of Georgia's (UGA's) Zoom platform, and interviews were recorded and transcribed. The study found that employees who display personal initiative perceive and experience this quality as being self-starting and proactive; use a "not waiting to be told" approach when it comes to learning on their own; understand the disadvantages of going

above and beyond in their roles; define personal initiative in the workplace as taking the initiative to find solutions to issues before they become problems; display interpersonal competence and a commitment to other team members; and report an impact on career achievement through promotions and growth opportunities and by gaining recognition from fellow team members. Findings also included participants' discussion of career achievement as encompassing more than salary.

This study's findings outline many attributes organizations seek when hiring employees and can inform the career readiness work of career development facilitators, human resource development professionals, and workforce development professionals.

INDEX WORDS: Achievement Motivation, Career Development, Goal Motivation, Interpersonal Skills, Organizational Citizenship Behavior, Personal Initiative, Proactive Behavior, Self-Determination, Self-Efficacy, Work Ethic

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DEDICATION

I dedicate this dissertation to my parents, Irene Elizabeth Conley and Cecil Conley. They are the source of my personal initiative and self-determination. Their love crosses the universe to lift me up and give me strength. I laugh as I can hear my father saying, “Li, get your lesson.”

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When I wrote my personal statement for my doctoral application, I had no idea that the two professors I quoted in that document would play such an essential role in completing my dissertation. Their work in Human Resource Development (HRD) seemed to align with where I

was when I submitted my application. I laugh as I think back to being in Dr. Hill's office on Homecoming Friday in 2016—nervous, wide-eyed, and ardently scribbling in my notebook in our first meeting. I feel so fortunate that I was assigned an advisor with such a calm demeanor. Right before oral comps, I recall telling Dean Spangler that I was scared, and she said, "Don't worry, Roger won't let you do something you are not ready for." She was right. Dr. Hill, I am so grateful for your support and gentle guidance; it was a Godsend.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Initiative is one of the top 10 essential skills employers seek in the college graduates they hire (NACE, 2015). *Personal initiative* refers to the actions an individual exhibits at work characterized by a self-starting nature, a proactive approach, and a persistence in overcoming problems that occur in the pursuit of a goal (Frese et al., 1996). Self-starting employees do things without being told, without receiving explicit instructions, and without specific role requirements (Frese & Fay, 2001). Highly proactive individuals recognize and act when they encounter opportunities and persist until they bring about significant change (Seibert et al., 1999). Though personal initiative has been researched as a behavioral theory, *initiative*—defined as “the energy or aptitude displayed at the start of action” (“Initiative,” n.d.)—is an old word. The origin of the word initiative comes from the Latin *initium*, which means beginning (“Initium,” n.d.).

As work continues to change, individuals in the workforce need to combine their thinking and technical skills with personal initiative. As a result of COVID-19, organizations are in crisis mode and experiencing unprecedented disruption. Employees must deal with complexity and adapt to the new realities of work (Dirani et al., 2020), while work environments are characterized by rapid and continuous changes that require organizations to rely on their employees' proactive contributions (Salanova & Schaufeli, 2008).

Many forces have contributed to the disruptive changes in the workforce landscape, including global connectivity, robotics, high-tech innovation, and new media (Davies et al., 2011). It is crucial for workers today to combine hard (i.e., technical expertise and knowledge)

and soft (i.e., character traits, attitudes, and behaviors) skills and attributes to engage in effective collaboration, communication, problem-solving, and critical thinking (Robles, 2012; Snape, 2017). Employees must respond to change when it occurs, requiring personal initiative and an independent response to shifting working conditions (Kivunja, 2015). There will be a premium for workers who set themselves apart by demonstrating these qualities in this era of rapid change. The dizzying pace of organizational change puts increased pressure on employees to frequently update their skills and adapt their behavior to new realities in the organization (DeShon & Gillespie, 2005).

Due to an increasing dependence on technology, entry into the contemporary workplace increasingly requires postsecondary education or training and more advanced intellectual skills than previous generations (Rojewski & Hill, 2017). These higher-order skills are numerous and varied. Sophisticated intellectual skills are needed because today's jobs entail higher levels of human interaction, requiring more advanced interpersonal and problem-solving skills. Interpersonal skills are the essential one-on-one skills applied when relating to other people (McConnell, 2018).

Success in the 21st century necessitates additional communication skills, technological savvy, a global view, collaborative practices, digital skills, and more innovative applications rather than memorization (Geisinger, 2016). Regardless of the description of these skills (essential, higher intellectual, higher-order, or soft), they continue to be indispensable. The routine, manual processing tasks that used to be handled by human beings are now increasingly handled by technology (Carnevale & Smith, 2013). To succeed in 21st century organizations, employees need skills that will empower them to think logically and solve problems independently (Kivunja, 2015).

A high degree of personal initiative allows people to make full use of both challenges and opportunities. Hite and McDonald (2020) noted:

The increasing interface of work and technology will inevitably include automation, as organizations seek options that would let them remain productive when the next pandemic strikes. A renewed push to automate will have short and long-term ramifications for the future of work and the economic security of workers. (p. 428)

When the COVID-19 crisis began, many workers shifted to working from home, leading organizations to discover that some jobs can be done from home and that online meetings are safe and cost-effective versus traveling to other parts of the world (Friedman, 2020). It is beneficial if the employees that work from home are self-starting and able to manage their time. Even for those going back to work in some hybrid mode, it will be increasingly important for employees to display personal initiative. Vestal (2009) noted that “personal initiative provides the ability to choose a course of action and act and represents a can-do spirit that motivates individuals to get things done” (p. 10).

Individuals exhibiting high personal initiative demonstrate self-initiated behavior that is meant to change their environment. They consider future opportunities and threats and prepare for their occurrence. They also strive to achieve their goals despite internal and external obstacles (Mensmann & Frese, 2019). Employees cannot always avoid problems, barriers, or setbacks when working on new projects and goals. Thus, when they deal with obstacles that get in their way and persist rather than giving up, they demonstrate personal initiative (Frese et al., 1996).

An important feature of personal initiative is that it has a long-term focus and often aims to anticipate future demands and prevent problems that reoccur (Fay & Sonnentag, 2002).).

Personal initiative allows individuals to deal more actively with work issues such as job stressors, job loss, career transitions, or becoming self-employed (Frese & Fay, 2001). Fay and Sonnentag (2002) studied the effects of stressors on personal initiative and noted that individuals show personal initiative to achieve work goals despite stressors. Stressors (broken machines or broken processes) are handled at the moment. However, improvement can be made by taking the initiative to remedy a problem not to reoccur in the future. For entrepreneurs, being a self-starter helps them differentiate their business from other businesses and creates a competitive advantage since unsuccessful ventures are often characterized by copying products or services that already exist without making innovative changes (Baum et al., 2014).

Research has found that managers rate individuals who take initiative as more employable (Frese et al., 1997), and such individuals earn more rewards and promotions and higher salaries (Seibert et al., 2001; Van Scotter et al., 2000). Employees who exhibit a high degree of personal initiative can provide new ideas, smoother production and service processes, more effective implementation of innovations, and, ultimately, better overall performance (Baer & Frese, 2003).

Being proactive is an attribute of personal initiative. Proactive individuals try to shape what happens in their lives (Grant & Ashford, 2008), taking advantage of opportunities and using self-initiated efforts to bring about change in their work environment and personal lives (Parker et al., 2010). Within organizations that seek to compete globally, fulfill client requests, and fully seize the prospects offered by flexible technologies, reliably carrying out a fixed set of prearranged responsibilities is no longer considered satisfactory work performance (Parker, 2000). Instead, maintaining a competitive advantage requires having flexible employees who use their knowledge proactively and exhibit personal initiative (Frese et al., 1996).

Employees who exhibit personal initiative enjoy taking on responsibilities with greater control and difficulty that offer them an active role in shaping their work (Frese et al., 2007). Brown et al. (2006) noted, “coinciding with previous theoretical work, empirical investigations have demonstrated that proactive individuals not only have greater professional success but also respond more adaptively to their environments” (p. 718). Workplaces are experiencing an increased interest in transferring power from the organization to the employee (Rigby & Ryan, 2018). Where responsibility shifts downward, employees need to be willing to take initiative without constant close supervision (Sonnentag, 2003).

Two decades ago, Frese and Fay (2001) observed that “future workplaces will require individuals to exhibit more personal initiative than ever before” (p. 133). COVID-19 has not only changed the workplace; it has also impacted our entire way of life and made preparing for the future of work a very urgent priority (Lund et al., 2020). COVID-19 forced remote, virtual, and flexible work to become more than a trend and required the current workforce to evolve rapidly

Essential skills will become even more critical with the advent of COVID-19, as jobs and teams continue with remote work. Agrawal et al. (2020) suggest that employee skills are critical to new business models and that the first step in developing these skills is to build a “no regrets” skill set—a toolkit that an employee can use no matter how their specific role evolves.

Displaying personal initiative will constitute an essential part of an employee’s toolkit as work continues to change.

Problem Statement

While initiative is one of the top 10 skills employers seek, business and industry surveys demonstrate that a lack of qualified workers is a significant concern of today's employers (Olinsky & Ayres, 2013). According to the Society for Human Resource Management (2015), self-direction, which is closely related to being self-starting (an attribute of personal initiative), is one of the top 10 skills college graduates lack. Today's workplace places a premium on initiative (Rojewski & Hill, 2017) as graduating students not only compete for jobs locally but must also compete on an international playing field. Students in the 21st century will potentially work for international organizations, manage employees from other cultures, and collaborate with people from around the world to solve global problems (Participate Learning, 2018).

Employers want employees with soft skills that are easily transferable from the classroom to the workplace (Deepa & Seth, 2013). Park and Hill (2016) noted, "these essential skills for the 21st century workplace are stressed repeatedly by scholars and other education experts" (p. 9). Personal initiative is an essential transferable soft skill. When deciding between two similar candidates, hiring managers agree that a candidate who demonstrates soft skills would have the edge over a candidate with few or no soft skill competencies (Stewart et al., 2016).

As Gusdorf (2008) reflected,

The strength of the economy and labor market will significantly affect an organization's ability to attract and retain top-level employees. When the economy is strong, with little unemployment, an organization may have to compete with other employers to find a limited number of skilled employees. The reverse may be true in a soft economy, with a high level of unemployment. The problem then is not a shortage of qualified applicants;

instead, the problem is managing the vast number of applications that must be pared down to find a few good hires. (p. 2)

As a career development facilitator working with employers who recruit students and with individuals who mentor students, I have heard these individuals express time and time again that they can train for the technical aspects of a position, but they cannot train for initiative.

Researchers have identified the attributes that comprise the construct of personal initiative. Frese et al. (1996) measured personal initiative quantitatively, and other researchers have included initiative in their quantitative inventories (Petty, 1993; Rojewski & Hill, 2014). Though we know employers want to hire individuals who already exhibit personal initiative, research on when and how personal initiative develops is limited. Sameroff (2010) has observed that “behavior, in general, and development, in particular, cannot be separated from the social context” (p. 13). Social experiences, in which individuals develop their self-image through complex interactions with others (Mead, 2015), help shape personal initiative.

Not much is known about personal initiative in a developmental context, and there is insufficient research on how personal initiative develops in childhood (Warner et al., 2017). If more can be discovered about the development of personal initiative, we can potentially expose students to interventions and scenarios that embed this training earlier in their career readiness preparation. While there is limited information on how and when personal initiative develops, research has shown that personal initiative can be cultivated. Glaub et al. (2014) conducted a controlled field intervention using the facets of personal initiative: self-starting (setting active goals), proactive (anticipating future opportunities) and overcoming barriers (continuing to work on goals when frustrated or taxed). The intervention increased the display of personal initiative and entrepreneurial success 12 months after the intervention. Developing countries still use this

training; at the end of 2019, approximately 5,000 entrepreneurs worldwide had the opportunity to participate in the training (Personal Initiative Training, n.d.). However, while personal initiative can be cultivated, it is less time-consuming and less costly for organizations to hire individuals who already demonstrate the behaviors that define personal initiative (Van Ronk, 2018).

Purpose of the Study

This research aimed to explore how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. Individuals exhibiting personal initiative are self-starting, proactive, and overcome barriers to achieve their goals (Frese & Fay, 2001). To understand how these employees perceived personal initiative, I conducted a *basic interpretive qualitative study* in which the researcher strives to comprehend the meaning participants take from a situation or phenomenon. This meaning is facilitated through the researcher as the instrument (Merriam & Tisdell, 2015). Throughout the qualitative research process, the researcher pays close attention to the meaning participants make based on their experiences in confronting a particular issue (Creswell & Poth, 2018).

Qualitative research is more suited than quantitative approaches to achieve the depth of understanding needed for this study. Qualitative research provides an understanding of the what, the how, and the why of emotional and experiential phenomena (Giacomini & Cook, 2000). While quantitative studies help identify the attributes that comprise personal initiative, little research has investigated how individuals perceive the impact of personal initiative on career achievement.

Qualitative studies seek to determine *why* people have thoughts and feelings that influence their behavior (Sutton & Astin, 2015). Creswell and Poth (2018) noted that “qualitative research begins with assumptions and the use of interpretive/theoretical frameworks that inform

the study of research problems addressing the meaning individuals or groups ascribe to a social or human problem” (p. 8). Studying personal initiative through a qualitative lens is essential because it allows themes to emerge from the participants’ own perspectives. In a basic interpretive qualitative study, the researcher strives to understand a process, the participants’ perspectives, or their worldviews, or all these things combined (Merriam & Tisdell, 2015).

This research sought to elicit employees’ perceptions of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. The study examined questions such as, how do participants define the concept of personal initiative? How has personal initiative shaped their work experience? Did personal initiative help them achieve their professional goals? This insight into personal initiative is significant because it comes from employees who display personal initiative and can speak on how it has impacted their career achievement. Their perceptions and career experiences can potentially provide the subject matter for future case studies and scenarios to help students develop personal initiative

This study explores the perceptions of employees working at a higher education institution in the Southeastern U.S. The employees were beyond their six-month probationary periods. The department head selected them based on the three main attributes of personal initiative: being a self-starter, being proactive, and being persistent in the face of barriers (Frese & Fay, 2001; Frese et al., 2007). The department head was instructed to select a mix of individuals: those who strongly demonstrate personal initiative, those who do not exhibit the behavior at all, and some who fall in the middle. Participants from the department heads’ selection pool were interviewed to obtain information about their perceptions of personal initiative. I chose to conduct the research with these employees because I have a relationship with this institution and access to the participants.

The following questions guided the research:

1. How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?
2. How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?
3. How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

Significance of the Study

Research-based interventions are critical in guiding school counselors' career readiness efforts, not only at the middle and high school levels but at the elementary school level (Knight, 2015). Though little is known about when personal initiative develops, this study's findings could inform training designed to enhance personal initiative and support implementing such training earlier in a student's career readiness journey. Since the 2008 recession, higher education institutions (HEIs) have placed a greater focus on career readiness and how effectively they prepare students for the workplace (Cruzvergara et al., 2018). As a career development practitioner in higher education, my work is dedicated to helping students prepare to enter the workforce, and thus the study results are important to me.

This research can also inform workforce development professionals. Jacobs and Hawley (2009) defined workforce development as "the coordination of public and private sector policies and programs that provide individuals with the opportunity for a sustainable livelihood and helps organizations achieve exemplary goals, consistent with the societal context" (p. 2543). As technology continues to advance, an increasing number of organizations require employees to meet stable, long-term objectives within transient and unpredictable environments (Crant, 2000; Friedman, 2005). Selection, placement, and training efforts may need to be tailored specifically to identifying and developing creative or innovative capabilities (Rank et al., 2004). This study

sought to add to the overall body of knowledge on personal initiative and contribute to the emerging literature on how personal initiative is perceived.

Theoretical Framework

According to Grant and Onsloo (2014), “The theoretical framework is the foundation from which all knowledge is constructed (metaphorically and literally) for a research study. The researcher’s choice of a theory provides the structure for the entire dissertation” (p. 12). To construct a theoretical framework, the writer needs to recognize and summarize a set of theoretical assumptions that describe the relationships among the phenomena they study (Camp, 2001). Multiple theories offer varying perspectives on the same issue. Thus, each researcher must decide which lens to use or blueprint to follow to build an argument, establish the context of the problem, define key constructs, and explain findings (Grant & Onsloo, 2014). *Constructs* are concepts or ideas about an object, attribute, or phenomenon worthy of measurement (Leggett, 2011). The constructs of work ethic, personal initiative, and proactive behavior form the framework for this qualitative study.

Work Ethic

Rojewski and Hill (2017) predicted that, work ethic and other human abilities will become more and more important as humans seek to one-up intelligent machines in an increasingly competitive work environment, given that intelligent machines can mimic but not develop or create such human assets on their own. (p. 187)

Personal initiative (PI) is one of these important human abilities. As Hill and Rojewski (1999) explain, “work ethic has been operationally defined as consisting of interpersonal skills, initiative, and being dependable” (p. 267).

The theoretical underpinnings of contemporary theory and research on work ethic are more than a century old, originating with the Protestant work ethic elaborated by Weber (1930/2013). Contemporary U.S. understandings of the work ethic evolved from the Protestant work ethic, which supported the vigorous pursuit of worldly success based on the belief that such success could be taken as a sign of eternal salvation (Weber, 1930/2013). Weber (1930/2013) argued that the Protestant work ethic was an important factor in the economic success of Protestant groups in the early stages of European capitalism. Weber's version of the Protestant work ethic viewed work as a calling predicated on a set of beliefs and conduct embodying self-discipline, hard work, frugality, conservation of resources, and deferment of immediate gratification (Mann et al., 2013).

Work ethic is a cultural norm that upholds personal accountability and responsibility for the work one does, with a foundation in the belief that work has intrinsic value (Hill & Petty, 1995). Mann et al. (2013) proposed that "work ethic is not a fixed global personality trait. Instead, work ethic is developed from personal experiences and learned from those in positions of influence (i.e., parents, bosses, teachers, neighbors, etc.)" (p. 68). Belief in the work ethic has been theorized as an individual difference developed early in life that can profoundly impact the development of adult work attitudes and behaviors (Saks et al., 1996).

Huang and Cappelli (2006) noted that employers screen candidates to find employees with a stronger work ethic. They also analyzed the relationship between higher productivity and performance. Individuals with a strong work ethic become more *employable*. Knight and Yorke (2004) defined employability "as a set of achievements, skills, understandings, and personal attributes that make it more likely for an individual to obtain employment and to become successful in their chosen occupations, benefitting themselves, the workforce, the community,

and the economy” (p. 36). A strong work ethic is beneficial across various professional contexts (Park & Hill, 2018).

Personal Initiative (PI)

Individuals who display personal initiative take an active and self-starting approach to work and exceed the formal requirements of a given job (Frese et al., 1997). Personal initiative is one aspect of the multidimensional concept of performance (Campbell et al., 1993; Fay & Sonnentag, 2002). Law et al. (1998) explained:

A construct is multidimensional when it consists of several interrelated attributes or dimensions and exists in multiple domains. In contrast to a set of interrelated unidimensional constructs, the dimensions of multidimensional constructs can be conceptualized under an overall abstraction, and it is theoretically meaningful and thrifty to use this overall abstraction as a representation of the dimensions. (p. 741)

Within this multidimensional concept, *in-role performance* refers to behaviors clearly required or expected by supervisors, coworkers, or job descriptions. *Extra-role performance* refers to voluntary actions *not* clearly demanded by supervisors and not identified in one’s job description (Fay & Sonnentag, 2002).

Van Dyne and LePine (1998) suggested that extra-role concepts can be ordered along two dimensions: affiliative–challenging and promotive. *Affiliative–challenging* refers to the degree to which a behavior is oriented toward preserving relationships (affiliative) versus the degree to which one focuses on substantive issues (challenges) while taking the risk of damaging relationships (Fay & Sonnentag, 2002). Most facets of organizational citizenship behavior (Organ, 1988) are typical examples of affiliative behaviors.

The *promotive* dimension refers to the degree to which a behavior is proactive and causes things to happen (Van Dyne & LePine, 1998). Extra-role performance concepts that emphasize challenging and promotive behaviors include actions beyond the practices presently applied within the organization (Fay & Sonnentag, 2002). Personal initiative is one example of an extra-role concept (Frese et al., 1996).

The Development of PI

Ryan and Deci (2000) asserted that “human beings can be proactive and engaged or, alternatively, passive and alienated, largely as a function of the social conditions in which they develop and function” (p. 68). Some children seek challenges, actively explore, and shape their environment, and take initiative from an early age. Other children are much more passive, rely heavily on adults, and have difficulty setting goals and taking action. These inter-individual differences reflect differences in children’s personal initiative (Warner et al., 2017). The nature vs. nurture question comes into play when identifying the source of these distinct characteristics (Sameroff, 2010).

From childhood to early adolescence, children develop the self-regulatory basis for complex higher-order thinking processes such as goal setting and planning ahead (Best & Miller, 2010; Bronson, 2000; Schneider, 2010). Hofmann et al. (2012) suggested that “self-regulation can be broadly defined as goal-directed behavior, typically within at least a minimum sequential perspective” (p. 174). Through self-regulation, individuals override and modify their responses, including altering themselves to live up to social and other standards (Baumeister et al., 2006). Accordingly, personal initiative represents a construct of proactive self-regulation. It differs from other self-regulation constructs in that it refers explicitly and exclusively to behavior that can be categorized as self-starting and proactive (Warner et al., 2017).

Prominent theories of self-regulated learning emphasize the importance of personal initiative in school. Researchers emphasize the necessity of self-defined goals, strategic planning, and perseverance during the learning process (Zimmerman, 2002). Students become less dependent on parents and teachers during elementary school, develop their own goals, and start to use learning strategies independently (Schunk & Zimmerman, 1997). One principal goal of children's general education is to cultivate their ability to display initiative and act in an independent and self-reliant way (Wollny et al., 2016).

Self-setting goals, using proactive approaches, and persisting despite barriers are all part of self-regulation and personal initiative (Frese & Fay, 2001). Some individuals take their goals very seriously, accomplish what they set out to do, avoid behaviors that do not advance them toward their goals, and immediately start to act once they have identified what they want to accomplish. Warner et al. (2017) explained:

Self-starting implies that children set goals that are not explicitly given and go beyond what is expected. Proactive implies that they adopt a long-term perspective, anticipate problems, and work towards future opportunities. Persistent implies that they actively face challenges and do not give up when pursuing a goal. (p. 114)

As children mature, their executive functions become more sophisticated and enable goal-directed behavior (Best & Miller, 2010). Broadly defined, *executive functions* include those cognitive processes that bring about goal-directed behavior and are stimulated by activity within the prefrontal cortex (Olson & Luciana, 2008). The prefrontal cortex is the gray matter of the anterior part of the frontal lobe, which is highly developed in humans and plays a role in the regulation of complex cognitive, emotional, and behavioral functioning ("Prefrontal Cortex," n.d.). Children and young adolescents increasingly comprehend their own thought processes and

cultivate more fine-tuned strategies to attain their goals (Demetriou, 2000; Schneider, 2010). In line with this development, children also take on increased responsibility and autonomy, rely less on their parents, and start to make their own decisions (Steinberg & Morris, 2001).

Social-cognitive theory, action theories, and constructivist theories postulate that humans influence their own development (Bandura, 2001; Haase et al., 2013; Piaget, 1983). Social-cognitive and relational perspectives on human development suggest that development always occurs in a (social) context (e.g., Bandura, 1986; Overton & Lerner, 2014). In this vein, researchers postulate that caregiving interactions play a prominent role in the developmental shift from external to internal control (Kopp, 1982; Schunk & Zimmerman, 1997). Among these caregiving interactions, positive parenting is one well-studied factor contributing to the development of self-regulatory skills.

Positive parenting is a broad concept encompassing parental warmth, support, appropriate discipline, and involvement in children's activities (Morrill et al., 2016). Positive parenting plays a vital role in framing internal control and self-efficacy beliefs, identified as important antecedents of personal initiative (Frese & Fay, 2001; Frese et al., 2007). For example, positive parenting transmits a sense of relatedness, which, according to self-determination theory, promotes self-reliance, confidence, and autonomy (Deci & Ryan, 1985). In contrast to harsh discipline and intrusiveness, positive parenting fosters a strong parent-child relationship and fuels children's well-being, self-regulation, and autonomy (Berger, 2011; Rodrigo, 2010).

The effects of positive parenting suggest that personal initiative can be nurtured in an individual. From this perspective, individuals who are not born with the ability to display personal initiative as a behavior (nature) can utilize assessments and inventories to identify their

weaknesses and enhance (nurture) this behavior. Regarding the nature-nurture debate, Moore (2015) observed:

For the longest time, the nature-nurture debate has been cast as a kind of contest between genes and experiences. The thought was that we might have some characteristics that are caused primarily by genetic factors and other characteristics that are caused primarily by experiential factors. Nature and nurture are always working together to produce all our traits. (p. 13)

Standing et al. (2015) took a different perspective on the role of nurture in fostering personal initiative, expanding on Iremonger's (1970) phaeton theory. The word *phaeton* is derived from the character Phaethon in Greek mythology. Zeus struck down Phaethon (the cast-off son of the Sun-god Helios) after he drove the chariot of his father too close to the earth ("Phaethon," 2019). Iremonger's (1970) *phaeton theory* argues "that individuals who demonstrate exceptional personal achievement in certain fields experienced childhoods marked by parental loss through death or abandonment" (p. 25). Standing et al. (2015) theorized that these children develop a strong drive to succeed early in life, and their experience of success and acclaim serves to numb the pain of the loss. Although researchers are just beginning to explore the development of personal initiative in children, the influence of personal initiative on adult performance and other favorable outcomes has been well documented (Warner et al., 2017).

Measuring PI

To explore aspects of the behavioral concept of personal initiative, Frese et al. (1996) developed the following scales:

1. General initiative at work: This refers to those actions at work that go beyond what is formally required in each job.

2. Overcoming barriers: Overcoming barriers looks at persistence despite barriers and setbacks and measures a person's tenacity when confronted with difficult situations in the pursuit of a goal. The interviewer presented some problems, such as what the participant would do if a colleague's work were sloppy, necessitating additional work by the participant to correct it.
3. Active approach: Proactivity was measured as whether people used an active approach to overcoming their barriers and kept initiative themselves or just delegated them to someone else.
4. Interviewer evaluation: The interviewers were asked to fill out a semantic differential scale to rate how active, initiating, and plan- and goal-oriented the interviewees were.
5. Education initiative: Education initiative measured interviewees' present participation in continuing work-related education and future plans to do so.

Factors That Influence PI

Despite differences in labels and theoretical underpinnings, concepts related to individual proactive behavior typically focus on self-initiated, future-oriented action that aims to change and improve the situation or oneself (Crant, 2000; Unsworth & Parker, 2003). Demonstrating personal initiative requires being self-starting, proactive, and persistent (Frese & Fay, 2001).

The attributes of personal initiative are developed to set goals, collect information, make plans, and obtain feedback (Frese & Fay, 2001). Human actions are goal-directed when intended to produce positive or desirable results (Marien et al., 2015). Among the can-do motivational states for personal initiative, *self-efficacy* captures individuals' assessment of their ability to perform general and specific tasks (Bandura, 1986).

While work ethic, personal initiative, and proactive behavior provide the theoretical framework for this study, personal initiative is related to many other constructs. These constructs will be discussed in more detail in the literature review in Chapter 2.

CHAPTER 2

LITERATURE REVIEW

The purpose of this chapter is to provide a framework for understanding personal initiative by reviewing previous scholarly literature. Frese et al. (1996) theorized personal initiative as related but not identical to other constructs, in particular, intrapreneurship (Hisrich, 1990); organizational citizenship behavior (OCB; Organ, 1990); and organizational spontaneity. This chapter presents research on behaviorism and personality trait theory as two of the foundations for personal initiative and proactive personality. I discuss the emergence of personal initiative as a theory, key attributes of personal initiative, and other parallel concepts. The chapter closes with a discussion of some critical areas of debate and gaps in the literature. This chapter is intended to introduce the theories most relevant to personal initiative, not to provide an extensive or exhaustive list.

Keywords used in this review's search strategy included, but were not limited to, *personal initiative*, *proactive behavior*, *organizational citizenship behavior*, *self-determination*, and *self-efficacy*. I conducted searches on ProQuest, ERIC, EBSCOHOST, ResearchGate, and Google Scholar to identify relevant peer-reviewed journal articles, books, and government reports. Older sources were included in the review to provide insight into the origins and history of the concepts.

Fundamental Background Theories

Behaviorism

The founder of behaviorism, American psychologist John B. Watson (1878-1958), proposed revolutionizing the study of human psychology by putting it on a firm experimental footing (Hauser, 2018). Behaviorism assumes that learners are mostly passive, responding to environmental stimuli. Learners start as a clean slate (*tabula rasa*), and their behavior is shaped through positive or negative reinforcement (Watson, 1930/2012).

Ivan Pavlov (1849-1936) was a Russian physiologist who conducted a series of experiments in which dogs were subjected to a sound directly before receiving food. Methodically, Pavlov controlled the start of the sound and the timing of the delivery of the food. Initially, the dogs would only salivate when they could see or smell the food, but after the sound and food were paired, the dogs also salivated in response to the sound (Pavlov, 1897/1902). This research resulted in the theory of *classical conditioning*. Classical conditioning is defined as conditioning in which the conditioned stimulus (such as the sound of a bell) is paired with and precedes the unconditioned stimulus (such as the sight of food) until the conditioned stimulus alone is sufficient to elicit the response (such as salivation in a dog) (Classical conditioning, n.d.). Walinga (2010) wrote, “as we learn, we alter the way we perceive our environment, the way we interpret the incoming stimuli, and therefore the way we interact, or behave” (Behaviorist psychology section, para 3).

B. F. Skinner (1904-1990) was an American psychologist who developed the theory of *operant conditioning*. In contrast to classical conditioning, operant conditioning learning occurs through reward and punishment. Operant conditioning is grounded in the belief that consequences shape behavior (Skinner, 1938). Skinner used the “Skinner Box” to study animal

behavior. There is usually a mechanism that an animal can operate in the box, and sometimes it will obtain food or water (positive reinforcement) within the chamber, or it will receive noise (negative reinforcement).

From a behavioral viewpoint, psychology is an objective, experimental branch of natural science. The theoretical goal of psychology is to predict and control behavior (Watson, 1913/1948). Behaviorists define learning as an observable change in behavior because of experience and repetition. This stimulus-response theory does not assess the mental processes necessary for learners to acquire, retain, and recall information (Clark, 2018). Instead, behaviorists believe learning begins when a cue or stimulus from the environment is presented, and the learner reacts to the stimulus with a response. This response is either reinforced or punished, and this process repeats so that the response becomes automatic (Kelly, 2012).

Understanding behavior in an organization is essential. Many companies are looking to assemble a behavioral science team—one that is located at the very center of their business and from which the entire organization can benefit (Martin & Ferrere, 2017). Behavioral science offers valuable insights into employee behavior and can be useful when communicating on HR issues. Some organizations have internal organizational development teams that conduct assessments and facilitate development. Also, behavioral science specialists can guide senior colleagues in the organization on the intricacies of human behavior to help them engage more effectively with employees (Wylie, 2017).

Action Theory

Frese et al. (1996) used action theory to explain personal initiative. Fay et al. (1998) defined an action as “behavior that is oriented towards a goal” (p. 174). According to action theory, people always plan actions to a certain extent—although planning may occur while they

are acting—and goals guide actions (Miller et al., 1960). Hacker (2003) theorized that the most important principle of action regulation is that goals control actions. From a cognitive perspective, these actions are anticipations of the results one intends to achieve. Action-oriented people do not think about the advantages and disadvantages of their goals; instead, they translate these goals quickly into actions. Thus, initiative implies goal-directedness and action orientation (Frese et al., 1996).

Personality Theory

Personal initiative and other theories similar to personal initiative as a construct are behavior-based theories. How people behave is, in part, the outcome of individual personality differences, but it is also a function of the situations in which individuals find themselves. Individuals are thus influenced both by their personality characteristics and by situations (Ariani, 2013). Personality traits can be understood as stable characteristics that influence a person's behavior in each situation (Bipp, 2010).

Personality is the set of psychological traits within structured and relatively permanent individuals, and that influences individuals' interactions with and adaption to physical and social environments (Larsen & Buss, 2017). However, researchers have established the existence of personality changes in childhood, adolescence, young adulthood, and middle age (Roberts et al., 2010). Personality traits are on a spectrum and it is important that these traits be observed in multiple scenarios. Trying to predict how personality influences behavior based on one interaction does not paint an accurate picture (Lumen Learning, n.d.).

Cattell (1943) developed a 16-item inventory of personality traits and created an instrument called the *Sixteen Personality Factor Questionnaire* (16PF) to measure these traits. McCrae and Costa (1985) expanded research in this area by introducing the NEO Personality

Inventory, consisting of 180 items with six facet scales for each of the Big Five personality domains: (1) Neuroticism (insecure, self-conscious, temperamental); (2) Extraversion (sociable, fun-loving, friendly); (3) Openness (original, imaginative, daring); (4) Conscientiousness (willpower, initiative, responsibility, self-discipline); and (5) Agreeableness (warm, friendly, tactful).

Conscientiousness is associated with task- and goal-directed behaviors (Jackson et al., 2010). Crant and Bateman (2000) theorized that individuals high in conscientiousness are achievement-oriented and set very clear goals for themselves. Individuals exhibiting personal initiative are also goal-directed. While there has not been a study of personality traits connected to personal initiative, Crant (2000) noted that “individuals with a prototypical proactive personality identify opportunities and act on them, show initiative, take action, and persevere until meaningful change occurs” (p.439). Although personal initiative and conscientiousness are conceptually distinct, both can be considered expressions of a need for achievement and may be empirically related (Frese et al., 1997).

Conscientiousness is central to the Big Five framework (Conejo et al., 2015). Colquitt et al. (2000) found a positive link between conscientiousness and the motivation to learn. Of all the Big Five dimensions, only conscientiousness consistently predicts job performance (Barrick et al., 2001). It also strongly correlates with job satisfaction (Judge et al., 2002) and career success (Judge et al., 1999).

An impressive body of literature has come to support the Big Five. Despite some variation, there is a general five-factor agreement among genders, age groups, self/peer ratings, longitudinal studies, and cross-cultural contexts (Conejo et al., 2015). There is thus consensus

that the Big Five likely represents the primary and universal personality dimensions (Cervone & Pervin, 2008).

The Emergence of Personal Initiative Theory

Initiative

The *Merriam-Webster Dictionary* defines *initiative* as the “energy or aptitude displayed in the initiation of action” (“Initiative,” n.d.). Initiative is not a new term and has been included in many other areas of research. For example, Petty (1993) identified 50 work ethic descriptors in developing the Occupational Work Ethic Inventory (OWEI). Instruments that accurately assess work ethic attributes are valuable for evaluating the workplace, using in instruction, and gathering data in research (Park & Hill, 2016). Career and technical education (CTE) and human resource development (HRD) professionals have used the OWEI extensively to measure work ethic constructs (Park & Hill, 2018), and initiative is included in the OWEI inventory. The following items are loaded on the inventory’s initiative factor: perceptive, productive, resourceful, initiating, ambitious, efficient, effective, enthusiastic, dedicated, persistent, accurate, conscientious, independent, persevering, and orderly (Petty & Hill, 2005).

The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) is an international organization that works to find evidence-based solutions to various social, economic, and environmental challenges (OECD, 2019). The OECD’s (2005) Definition and Selection of Competencies (DeSeCo) Project’s conceptual framework classified key competencies into three broad categories:

First, individuals need to be able to use a wide range of tools for interacting effectively with the environment: both physical ones such as information technology and socio-cultural ones such as the use of language. Second, in an increasingly interdependent

world, individuals need to be able to engage with others. Since they will encounter people from a range of backgrounds, it is important that they are able to interact in heterogeneous groups. Third, individuals need to be able to take responsibility for managing their own lives, situate their lives in the broader social context, and act autonomously. (p. 5)

Setting, prioritizing, and refining goals and projecting future outcomes are all part of the act autonomously competency. As personal initiative attributes include being self-starting and persisting in the face of barriers to achieve goals (Frese et al., 1996), the OECD competencies are comparable.

The National Research Council (2013) identified three broad domains of competence: cognitive, intrapersonal, and interpersonal. The Council conducted a content analysis and combined several lists of 21st century skills included in research-based classifications. The *cognitive* domain involves reasoning and memory; the *intrapersonal* domain consists of managing one's behavior and emotions to attain one's goals (including learning goals). The *interpersonal* domain includes expressing ideas and interpreting messages from others. Initiative is part of the intrapersonal domain.

Rojewski and Hill (2014) identified work ethic, career navigation, and innovation as essential competencies that job seekers and employees must develop in the 21st century workplace. Dependability, initiative, and interpersonal skills emphasizing communication skills were encompassed within the work ethic element. While initiative is included in many inventories, Frese et al. introduced personal initiative as a theory in 1996.

Personal Initiative

Frese et al. (1996) introduced personal initiative using interviews and questionnaire-based scales to measure the concept in interrelated studies (two waves from a longitudinal study in East Germany and a cross-sectional study in West Germany). During East Germany's 40 years of bureaucratic socialism, its citizens had little chance to express initiative at work, as behavior by and within companies was highly regulated by central planning. Differences in personal initiative were hypothesized to be the results of occupational socialization, particularly work control and complexity, rather than a selection effect. A representative longitudinal study was conducted in the East and a cross-sectional study in the West. Results found lower initiative at work in the East; control and complexity affected changes in initiative. The authors determined that higher initiative existed among small-scale entrepreneurs in the East and among those who got a job more quickly.

Frohman (1997) studied how micro approaches to change help organizations adapt. He analyzed successful examples of incremental change in two dozen organizations ranging in size from a \$5 million contract research and design organization to several top-10 Fortune 500 industrial companies. From the study, he introduced the term *initiators* to designate those who were driven by what they felt the organization needed to accomplish.

Initiators did not merely do their jobs but took the initiative to go far beyond their stated job requirements. Frohman (1999) identified four characteristics of individuals who drove successful innovations:

- (a) Initiators question data aggressively to identify problems and opportunities outside their area of responsibility. Initiators did not wait for direction but actively sought out new opportunities or identified problems.
- (b) Initiators will be driven by internal forces to

learn, and what will be learned is focused on solving critical business problems and pushing the innovation. (c) Initiators directed their actions for results. They followed their own lead toward project completion. (d) Initiators examine and align strong personal beliefs with the organization's values. (p. 35)

Frohman's (1999) attributes of directing one's own action and aligning personal beliefs with the organization's values are very similar to Frese et al.'s (1996) identification of self-direction and alignment with the organization's mission as attributes of personal initiative. However, Frohman's 1997 and 1999 articles did not reference the work of Frese and his colleagues.

Key Attributes of Personal Initiative

Proactivity

Proactivity reflects the complementary inclinations and actions individuals carry out to shape themselves and their environments (Bateman & Crant, 1993; Grant & Ashford, 2008). Bateman and Crant (1993) investigated the proactive component of organizational behavior and introduced the measure of *proactive personality*. This measure of personality is intended to recognize differences among people in the extent to which they take action to influence their surroundings.

Bateman and Crant (1993) developed the Proactive Personality Scale (PPS) to measure this construct and provided evidence for the scale's convergent, discriminant, and predictive validity with results from three studies. Phase One was composed of undergraduates who completed the initial proactive scale, producing data used to create a revised, unidimensional scale. Scores on the proactive scale correlated with the need for achievement, need for dominance, independent measures of the nature of subjects' extracurricular and civic activities,

the nature of their significant personal achievements, and peer nominations of transformational leaders.

Phase Two consisted of undergraduates who completed the revised proactive scale and measures of the Big Five personality constructs: extraversion, openness, agreeableness, conscientiousness, and neuroticism (Pervin & John, 1999). In Phase Three, the participants were MBA students. The researchers assessed the proactive scale's relationships to three personality traits (need for achievement, need for dominance, and need for a locus of control) and three criterion measures (the nature of the students' extracurricular and civic activities, personal achievements, and transformational leadership).

Whereas some people react to, adapt to, and are shaped by their environments, proactive people draw on personal initiative to impact the world around them (Bakker et al., 2012). Frese et al. (2007) explained that:

Proactivity means to have a long-term focus and not to wait until one must respond to a demand. A long-term focus at work enables the individual to consider things to come (new demands, new or reoccurring problems, and emerging opportunities) and to do something about them now. Thus, the person anticipates problems and opportunities and prepares to deal with the problems and take advantage of opportunities. (p. 1085)

Proactive behavior can achieve meaningful outcomes, including improved job performance and satisfaction, career success, and organizational prosperity (DuBrin, 2013). Employees exhibiting high personal initiative are more self-reliant and independent in acquiring new knowledge than those who lack personal initiative (Frese & Fay, 2001). The emerging view of the proactive employee is that of an individual who is highly involved and committed, an

independent contributor with initiative, and a well-developed sense of responsibility (Campbell, 2000).

Highly proactive people identify opportunities, act on them, display initiative, and persevere until they bring about meaningful change (Seibert et al., 1999). Seibert et al. (2001) linked the actions that accompany a proactive approach to the likelihood of attaining job satisfaction:

Being an innovator rather than a status quo-oriented employee, engaging in behaviors to become more politically astute rather than ill-versed, and actively engaging in career planning and seeking career-related feedback are specific actions one can take to enhance the likelihood of an extrinsically rewarding and intrinsically satisfying career. (p. 866)

Proactive Behavior vs. Personal Initiative

Proactive behavior refers to anticipatory action that employees take to impact themselves and their environments (Grant & Ashford, 2008). One of the key characteristics of personal initiative is persistence in the face of setbacks (Frese et al., 1996). For people with a proactive personality, persistence is one of the critical differentiators of success. People who persist take that extra step that might take them away from the threshold of failure (Van Rooy, 2014).

Another component of personal initiative is the ability to overcome barriers. Overcoming barriers looks at persistence despite restrictions and measures a person's tenacity when confronted with difficult situations in pursuit of a goal (Frese et al., 1997). Studies have found that proactive leaders have an internal locus of control and are less likely to let outside factors negatively weigh them down (Van Rooy, 2014).

Proactivity and personal initiative are also connected to organizational behavior. The field of organizational behavior (OB) draws on psychology, sociology, and anthropology

principles to understand how people behave in organizational work environments. OB incorporates three primary levels of analysis: individuals, groups, and the organization (Ashkanasy & Dorris, 2017).

The discipline of OB comes from the work of psychologist Kurt Lewin (1890-1947). Lewin proposed that human behavior should be understood in terms of a continuum with individual variations from the norm, a function of tensions between perceptions of the self and the environment (“Kurt Lewin,” 2019). Lewin used the term *field theory* for his psychological theory, which examines patterns of interaction between individuals and the whole field, or the surrounding environments in which they move (Burnes & Bargal, 2017).

The term *proactive* is defined as acting in anticipation of future problems, needs, or changes; its opposite, *reactive*, means to be responsive to a stimulus (“Proactive,” n.d.). Words related to proactive include *visionary* and *forward-looking*. *Initiative* is defined as the energy and desired that is needed to do something. Words related to initiative include ambition, drive, go, grit, and hustle (“Initiative,” n.d.). An individual might possess a great deal of initiative but might not necessarily be forward-looking. At the same time, a forward-looking person may lack initiative.

Goal-Setting Motivation Theory

Motivation refers to internal factors that spur action and to external factors that can be stimuli for action (Locke & Latham, 2002). Motives are reasons people hold for initiating and performing voluntary behavior. Motives often shape a person’s perception, reasoning, emotion, and behavior (Reiss, 2004).

Goal-setting motivation theory emphasizes the meaningful relationship between goals and performance. The foundation of goal-directed action is biology. Life is a conditional process;

it requires action that sustains survival. At the human level, there is a need for conceptual thought (reason), volitional goal choices, and long-range thinking (Locke, 2018). Latham and Locke (1991) found that setting specific, challenging goals led to higher performance levels than setting unclear goals or not setting goals. Another aspect of goal-setting motivation theory is feedback regarding one's progress towards their goal. For goals to be meaningful, individuals must receive input that tracks their progress toward their objectives. In the absence of feedback, it is difficult to fine-tune one's performance strategies to match what the goal requires (Locke & Latham, 2002).

According to Locke and Latham (2019), "commitment is especially important when a goal is difficult to attain because the goal requires more effort and persistence when setbacks are inevitably experienced. Commitment is affected by values, including incentives, and self-efficacy" (p. 98). Goal difficulty is the degree to which a goal is challenging and necessitates effort (Locke & Latham, 2002). If people work to achieve goals, it is reasonable to assume they will work harder to attain their more challenging goals. Goal difficulty is aligned with the characteristic of overcoming barriers in personal initiative theory. Overcoming barriers looks at persistence despite restrictions and measures a person's tenacity when confronted with difficult situations in pursuit of a goal (Frese et al., 1997).

Persistence

Feather (1962) noted, "persistence may be distinguished from the performance level or effort involved in an activity and from the direction which an activity takes; however, it belongs with both as an important indicator of motivation" (p. 94). Cloninger et al. (1993) defined persistence as perseverance despite fatigue or frustration. Cloninger et al. (1993) developed the

Tridimensional Personality Questionnaire, a self-report personality inventory measuring three major personality dimensions: novelty seeking, harm avoidance, and reward dependence.

Cloninger et al. (1993) also defined three dimensions of character: *self-directedness*, *cooperativeness*, and *self-transcendence*. The first dimension, *self-directedness* (SD), is defined as the individual capacity to adapt to different situations that must be addressed to obtain personal objectives. The second dimension, *cooperativeness* (C), refers to the capacity to understand and accept others, in contrast to self-centeredness and hostility. The third dimension, *self-transcendence* (ST), is associated with the presence of spirituality, that is, the sentiment of belonging to a unified whole.

Constantin et al. (2011) developed a scale measuring motivational persistence, where persistence is defined as the tendency to remain engaged in specific goal-related activities despite difficulties, obstacles, fatigue, prolonged frustration, or low perceived feasibility. Drawing on existing theoretical models of persistent behavior, they proposed a model that included will and cognitive, motivational aspects. Their study concluded that the cognitive motivational quality of suspended pursuits is an important component of continuity of behaviors, which protects against the instability of strivings and is distinct from other phenomena such as unwanted reflections.

Self-Starting Concepts

The *Merriam-Webster Dictionary* defines a *self-starter* as a person who can work without needing a lot of instruction or help (“Self-starter,” n.d.). Individuals who are self-starters manage and lead themselves to practice self-observation, goal setting, and self-reinforcement. They establish self-direction, build natural rewards into work, and engage in

constructive thought patterns (Andrasik & Heimberg, 1982; Manz, 1986, 1992; Manz & Sims, 1980).

Self-determination Theory (SDT)

Self-determination theory is a theory of human motivation, development, and wellness that uses empirical methods while employing organismic metatheory to highlight the importance of humans' evolved inner resources for personality development and behavioral self-regulation (Ryan et al., 1997). *Self-determination* refers to the process of defining one's direction. Self-determination in employment means that job seekers discover their wants and needs, define their employment goals, and choose the resources that will enable them to achieve those goals (Brugnaró & Timmons, 2007).

In SDT, various constructs—autonomy support, psychological needs, and motivation—explain the physical activity behavior change process. Legault (2017) noted that “SDT defines intrinsic and several types of extrinsic motivation and outlines how these motivations influence situational responses in different domains, as well as social and cognitive development and personality” (p.1).

Three main types of motivation exist within SDT: amotivation, extrinsic, and intrinsic (Sweet et al., 2012). In *amotivation*, an individual does not feel in control, and the locus of control is perceived as external (Ryan & Deci, 2000). In other words, they lack a sense of control with respect to attaining a desired outcome (Calvo et al., 2010). *Intrinsic motivation* refers to doing something because it is fundamentally stimulating. In *extrinsic motivation*, people do something because it leads to a distinguishable outcome (Ryan & Deci, 2000). An example of extrinsic motivation might be a professional athlete remaining under a specific bodyweight to receive a bonus outlined in their contract.

Deci and Ryan (1985) developed and validated a causation scale to measure causality orientations, which they conceptualized as relatively enduring aspects of individuals that characterize their source of initiation and regulation, and thus their degree of self-determination. SDT focuses on the types rather than the amount of motivation, paying attention to autonomous motivation, controlled motivation, and amotivation as predictors of performance, relational, and well-being outcomes (Deci & Ryan, 2008). As a motivational theory, SDT addresses what energizes behavior and moves people to action and how their behavior is regulated in the various domains of their lives (Smelser & Baltes, 2001).

Self-efficacy Theory (SET)

Self-efficacy refers to an individual's belief in their ability to complete the behaviors needed to achieve specific performance objectives (Bandura, 1997). High self-efficacy leads to more ambitious goals and greater persistence when difficulties arise (Bandura, 1991). Employees with high self-efficacy beliefs tend to attach a higher likelihood of success to personal initiative (Bledlow & Frese, 2009).

Bandura (1977) introduced an integrative theoretical framework to explain and predict psychological changes achieved by different modes of treatment. This theory stated that psychological methods, whatever their form, alter the level and strength of self-efficacy. Bandura hypothesized that the belief of personal efficacy (worth) determines whether coping behavior will start, how much effort will be spent, and how long effort will continue in the face of hindrances and aversive experiences.

Efficacious people take advantage of opportunity structures quickly and figure out ways to sidestep institutional limitations or change them through collective action (Bandura, 1997). Self-efficacy is a future-oriented belief about the level of competence a person expects they will

display in a given situation (Tschannen-Moran & McMaster, 2009). Self-efficacy beliefs stimulate thought patterns and emotions that allow goal-directed actions in situations where people believe they can exert some self-control (Tschannen-Moran & McMaster, 2009).

Self-efficacy vs. Self-determination

SET and SDT are closely aligned in that both are based on the belief that humans are agents of their actions (Sweet et al., 2012). Both concepts are grounded in the social cognitive theory of human behavior, which views behavior as comprehensively motivated and regulated by the continuing application of self-influence. Self-regulation also encompasses the self-efficacy mechanism, which plays a central role in the exercise of personal agency through its strong impact on thought, affect, motivation, and action (Bandura, 1991). Sweet et al. (2012) observe:

In SDT, the concept of competence/self-efficacy is a more distal factor to behavior because it is hypothesized to have a direct relationship with self-determined motivation rather than behavior. In contrast, self-efficacy directly influences behavior, making it a more proximal factor in SET. (p. 320)

Self-regulation Theory

According to Bandura (1991), self-regulation operates through three principal sub-functions:

These include self-monitoring of one's behavior, its determinants, and effects; judgment of one's behavior in relation to personal standards and environmental circumstances; and affective self-reaction. Self-regulation also encompasses self-efficacy, which plays a central role in personal agency by its strong impact on thought, affect, motivation, and action. (p. 248)

Kuhl (1992) conceptualized self-regulation as a “democratic” mode of will in which individuals create goals according to their needs and preferences (self-determination), regulate emotions in contexts that are adequate, and flexibly resolve action-related conflicts. Baumeister and Vohs (2007) theorized self-regulation as the ability to alter one’s behavior, which significantly increases the flexibility and adaptability of human behavior and enables individuals to adapt their actions to an extensive range of social and situational demands. Baumeister and Vohs (2007) identified the ingredients of the self-regulation process as follows: standards of desirable behavior, monitoring of situations and thoughts that precede breaking standards, self-regulatory strength (willpower), allowing one’s internal strength to control urges, and motivation to meet standards.

Personal Initiative: Parallel Literature

Grit

Duckworth et al. (2007) defined *grit* as “perseverance and passion for long-term goals” (p. 1087). Individuals with high grit levels are thought to be able to utilize their abilities better because they are less preoccupied with short-term goals. They are not disheartened by the failures and setbacks that are generally encountered in many performance domains (Credé et al., 2017).

The Duckworth et al. (2007) research team established a psychometric scale that measured grit using a self-report questionnaire. The findings suggested that achieving challenging goals involves talent and the continuous and focused application of talent over time. Grit did not have a positive relationship with IQ but was highly related to the Big Five characteristic of conscientiousness (Duckworth et al., 2007). As noted earlier, both personal initiative and conscientiousness are considered expressions of a need for achievement and may,

therefore, be empirically related (Frese et al., 1997). Given that one of the attributes of personal initiative is persistence in the face of barriers and setbacks (Frese et al., 1996), grit and personal initiative are parallel constructs.

Intrapreneurship

Pinchot (1985) defined intrapreneurs as:

dreamers who do. Those who take hands-on responsibility for creating innovation of any kind within an organization; they may be the creators or inventors but are always the dreamers who figure out how to turn an idea into a profitable reality. (p. 28)

de Jong and Wennekers (2008) theorized that intrapreneurship's key behavioral aspects are personal initiative, active information search, out-of-the-box thinking, voicing, championing, taking charge, finding a way, and some degree of risk-taking. Intrapreneurs utilize the company's existing assets, and they work inside organizations that have preexisting policies and bureaucracy (Blanka, 2019).

Innovative Work Behavior (IWB)

Scott and Bruce (1994) explained that individual innovation begins with problem recognition and generating ideas or solutions, either novel or adopted. They hypothesized that leadership, individual problem-solving style, and team relations impact innovative behavior directly and indirectly through their influence on perceptions of the environment for innovation. Their research found that leadership, support for innovation, managerial role expectations, career stage, and systematic problem-solving style were significantly related to individual innovative behavior.

Based on an extensive literature review and two empirical studies, de Jong (2007) developed a multidimensional measure called innovative work behavior (IWB). As a source of

items, he used earlier measures including those of Scott and Bruce (1994); Tierney, Farmer, and Graen (1999); Kleysen and Street (2001); and Janssen (2000). The inventory contained measures related to opportunity exploration, idea generation, championing, and application.

Intrapreneurship vs. Innovative Work Behavior

de Jong and Wennekers (2008) explained that intrapreneurship and innovative work behavior are closely related concepts and elaborated on their similarities and differences, stating:

Innovative work behavior and intrapreneurship overlap in so far as both may refer to innovative initiatives with a wider meaning for the business than one's work only involving the overcoming of barriers and the acceptance of some risk. Innovative work behavior differs from intrapreneurship when the innovation is restricted to improving one's work or when no barriers or risks are involved. In these cases, innovative work behavior is usually more of a managerial than an entrepreneurial nature (improving things, given the resources available (p. 26)

Organizational Citizenship Behavior (OCB)

The foundations of organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) are rooted in Barnard's (1968) notion that individuals' willingness to cooperate is essential and indispensable to an organization. Similarly, Katz (1964) alluded to OCB with the assertion that in addition to entering and remaining with the organization and meeting performance metrics, employees must go beyond their roles with spontaneity. The phrase *organizational citizenship behavior*, however, was coined by Smith et al. (1983).

These researchers were interested in why job satisfaction is vital to organizations, given that the concept has a weak connection to job performance. Organ (1988) defined OCB as:

Individual behavior that is discretionary, not directly or explicitly recognized by the formal reward system, and that in the aggregate promotes the effective functioning of the organization. By discretionary, we mean that the behavior is not an enforceable requirement of the role or the job description, that is, the specifiable terms of the person's employment contract with the organization; the behavior is rather a matter of personal choice, such that its omission is not generally understood as punishable. (p. 4)

Podsakoff et al. (1990) developed the OCB scale based on concepts developed by Organ (1988). The OCB scale consists of a 24-item, 7-point scale used to assess five categories of organizational citizenship behavior including, (a) altruism, (b) conscientiousness, (c) sportsmanship, (d) courtesy, and (e) civic virtue (Kegans et al., 2012). Organ et al. (2006) defined these categories as follows:

- Altruism: Discretionary behaviors on the part of employees that have an effect of helping a specific other with an organizationally related problem.
- Conscientiousness: Discretionary behaviors on the part of the employee that go well beyond the minimum role requirements of the organization in the areas of attendance, obeying rules and regulations, taking breaks, and so forth (p. 251). Conscientiousness is also part of the Big Five personality traits (McCrae & Costa, 1985).
- Sportsmanship: Willingness of the employee to tolerate less than ideal circumstances without complaining—to “avoid complaining, petty grievances, railing against real or imagined slights, and making federal cases out of small potatoes” (Organ, 1988, p. 11).
- Courtesy: Discretionary behavior on the part of an individual aimed at preventing work-related problems with others from occurring.

- Civic Virtue: Behavior on the part of an individual that indicates that he or she responsibly participates in, is involved in, or is concerned about the life of the company (Podsakoff et al., 1990).

Both OCB and initiative go beyond specified role requirements and contribute indirectly to organizational effectiveness (Organ, 1988). The degree to which an employee displays OCB, or any behavior is a function of the employee's ability, motivation, and opportunity (Organ et al., 2006).

Organizational Spontaneity

Katz (1964) identified three categories of employee behavior that are essential for organizational effectiveness. Individuals must be induced to enter and remain with an organization; as employees, they must carry out specific role requirements in a dependable fashion; and they must engage in spontaneous activity that goes beyond role descriptions. Such extra-role behavior may be directed towards an individual, the group, or the organization as a unit to promote organizational goals (Somech & Drach-Zahavy, 2000).

Personal initiative is one example of an extra-role concept (Frese et al., 1996). George and Brief (1992) viewed spontaneous behaviors as extra-role behaviors that are performed voluntarily and contribute to organizational effectiveness. Such behaviors are based on their benefits for the organization rather than on their potential incentive value for the individual.

Personal Initiative: Key Areas of Debate

This study operated from the foundation that personal initiative and proactive behavior are positive behavioral aspects for the individual and desired by the organization. However, displaying these behaviors is not always a good thing. Two challenges associated with

proactivity at the organizational level are generating high proactivity levels and managing the risks associated with such levels (Bateman & Crant, 1999).

Employees must know how far to go with personal initiative while also recognizing how far is too far. Glaser et al. (2016) tested a multilevel model that explained how personal initiative's performance outcomes depend on the scope of alignment between organizational control mechanisms and proactive individuals' risk propensities. The role of organizational control is to provide measures and rewards such that employees pursuing their self-interest will be aligned with the organizations' goals (Akdere & Azevedo, 2006).

In contrast to prior assertions that proactive individuals must be willing to take risks (Fay & Frese, 2000), Glaser et al. (2016) suggested that individuals with higher risk propensities are less effective in controlling the risks associated with initiative. A critical insight from the study was that the organizational control mechanisms that increase the performance benefits of personal initiative were distinctly different for individuals with low- and high-risk propensities (Glaser et al., 2016). Innovation processes are unpredictable, controversial, and in competition with alternative courses of action (Kanter, 1988). Consequently, innovation arises from risky work behaviors that may lead to unintended costs for the innovators, despite their aim to produce anticipated benefits (Janssen et al., 2004).

Recognizing that individuals can take initiative that has functional value for them but is harmful for the organization, Fay and Frese (2000) measured only personal initiative that was conceptualized to help advance the group or organization. Supervisors do not always appreciate proactive workers; as a result, they may fall short on incentives and sometimes even reprimand employees for engaging in proactive behavior (Grant et al., 2009). Morrison and Milliken (2000) noted that many supervisors feel a strong need to avoid embarrassment, threat, and feelings of

vulnerability or incompetence. As a result, they tend to avoid any information that might suggest weakness or raise questions about current courses of action.

Personal initiative involves anticipating future developments and proactively taking action to address them. Doing so often ignites resistance from others who oppose proposed changes and seek to prevent initiatives from having an impact (Ashford & Black, 1996). Some researchers have, therefore, investigated the adverse effects of personal initiative and proactive behavior on the individual employee.

Bolino et al. (2010) found that employees often engage in citizenship behaviors because they feel pressured by their organization. Over a prolonged period, individuals with high personal initiative may get tired of going the extra mile, especially when there is no recognition or compensation for their efforts. Data from two multi-source field studies and an online experiment by Yam et al. (2017) demonstrated that employees might believe they are providing something above and beyond the needs of the job and have therefore earned something more than what is being offered by the organization.

While proactivity in an individual's career has positive outcomes, most measures of positive outcomes have only been done within single countries (Smale et al., 2018). Not all cultures may view taking initiative and being a self-starter in the same way. Culture is a practice of values, practices, attitudes, and behavioral standards that are shared by members of a societal group (Thomas & Peterson, 2015). Smale et al. (2018) studied 11,982 employees from 22 countries and highlighted the complex role of national culture in shaping the outcomes of proactivity in careers. It must be considered that national culture influences how individuals interpret the importance of taking initiative and being proactive.

Gaps in the Literature

Going the extra mile may impact an employee mentally and physically. There is limited research on the effects of proactive behavior on the individual. Organ and Ryan (1995) first noted that employees who engage in organizational citizenship behavior might feel overloaded. Bolino et al. (2010) argued that longitudinal studies on proactive behavior are needed because proactive behavior may negatively affect employees' well-being over time. Engagement in OCB may reduce in-role performance, limit employees' career success, increase turnover, and make the organization a less appealing place to work (Bergeron et al., 2013).

Zacher et al. (2019) investigated the effects of personal initiative on engagement and exhaustion. Their findings suggested that changes in personal initiative may indirectly influence emotional engagement and exhaustion via positive moods and negative moods when perceived organizational support is low. *Perceived organizational support* refers to employees' perceptions that the organization values the contributions they make at work and pays attention to their well-being (Eisenberger et al., 1986).

Bolino and Turnley (2005) found that individual initiative was positively related to increased levels of role overload, job stress, and work-family conflict. Findings indicated that engaging in some forms of OCB can undermine critical indicators of employee well-being, which may require additional administrative resources to combat (Bolino & Turnley, 2005; Halbesleben et al., 2009). Bolino et al. (2015) studied an additional aspect of OCB that may also be harmful, known as citizenship fatigue. *Citizenship fatigue* is defined as a state in which employees feel worn out, tired, or on edge due to engaging in OCB. Thus, an increase in proactive behavior can have detrimental effects on occupational well-being (Zacher et al., 2019).

Summary

This literature review provided the theoretical foundations for personal initiative as a theory, including behaviorism and personality trait theory. The chapter also discussed how the theory of personal initiative emerged and provided a description of personal initiative's key attributes, including proactivity, self-starting concepts, and persistence. The chapter provided a glimpse into the literature on concepts parallel to personal initiative and identified some key areas of debate. The chapter concluded with a discussion of gaps in the literature.

CHAPTER 3

METHOD

This research explored how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. Frese and Fay (2001) defined personal initiative as proactive, self-starting work behavior that allows individuals to overcome barriers and achieve their goals. This study explored the perspectives of employees working at a higher education institution in the Southeast. To explore how these employees perceived the concept of personal initiative, I utilized a basic qualitative research design. The following questions guided the research:

1. How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?
2. How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?
3. How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

Research Design

Farber (2006) reflected, “the first step in any research project is to identify what you want to understand. Research begins with wonder” (p. 367). In this study, I sought to gain insight into employees’ perceptions of personal initiative related to their work and careers. As I was interested in their perceptions and experiences, a basic qualitative research design was the best choice for this study. In a basic qualitative study, the researcher is interested in how people interpret their experiences, how they construct their worlds, and what meaning they assign to their experiences (Merriam & Tisdell, 2015).

Qualitative approaches have two things in common. First, they usually emphasize phenomena that are happening or have previously happened in natural settings. Second, they involve collecting and studying the complexity of those phenomena (Leedy & Ormrod, 2016). According to Denzin and Lincoln (2017),

qualitative research involves the studied use and collection of a variety of empirical materials: case studies, personal experiences, introspection, life stories, interviews, artifacts, and cultural texts, and other products that describe routine and problematic moments and meanings in individuals' lives. (p. 10)

Research Site

A researcher's means of obtaining access to the research field can vary considerably depending on the kinds of investigated cases (Johl & Renganathan, 2010). Shenton and Hayter (2004) noted that "an arrangement may be reached in which a manager at the executive level contacts the appropriate organizations in advance of the researcher approaching them and draws attention to the fact that the project has received official approval" (p. 224). The site of this study is a higher education institution in the Southeast. The university is a medium-sized institution, with an enrollment in the range of 5,000-15,000 students (CollegeData.com, 2020).

Access to the Site

Researchers must be careful in choosing a location for their interviews, as any given location is a setting for various social, political, and economic relations. Interviews can often yield a rich body of information. A researcher might ask questions about individuals' biographical information, beliefs, and perspectives about facts and feelings (Silverman, 1993). Face-to-face interviews have the unique benefit of allowing the researcher to establish rapport with potential participants, thereby gaining their cooperation (Leedy & Ormrod, 2016). Because

the interview site provides a space for the enactment and constitution of power relations, choosing a location is a complicated decision with wide-reaching implications (Elwood & Martin, 2000).

The initial plan was to interview participants at a location near their work setting. Bhattacharya (2008) noted that the research setting could be understood as the cultural, social, and physical site where a study is conducted. The main emphasis in qualitative research is making meaning, and participants are studied in their natural setting. However, on March 12, 2020, the University System of Georgia informed students that instruction would be suspended for two weeks. When instruction resumed, it was conducted entirely online for the remainder of the semester and through the summer. This change in instruction eventually led the IRB to announce that interviews for ongoing approved research would need to be conducted remotely due to COVID-19. As a result, participants in this study were not interviewed in person or at a location near their work.

Instead, interviews were conducted using UGA's Zoom application. Zoom is a cloud-based platform for video, voice, content sharing, and chatting that can run across mobile devices, telephones, desktops, and room systems (Zoom, n.d.). Though voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP) telephony is convenient and interactive, qualitative researchers have discussed many ethical and practical issues when using this technology (Archibald et al., 2019). In contrast, an advantage of Zoom is the security features that include an end-to-end encrypted meeting, secure log-in using username and password, the ability to start a secured meeting with a password, and the ability to schedule meetings with a password (Zoom Video Communications Inc., 2016).

With the Zoom application's help, participants could engage in the interviews from their selected settings. However, I did not ask about their surroundings as I was mindful that not

everyone has an office to conduct teleconference meetings. I did not want to make a participant uncomfortable about their natural setting; thus, I cannot provide rich information about the setting of the data collection.

Interviews for this study were conducted between April 16, 2020, and May 1, 2020. The average interview time was 50 minutes for each participant, with the shortest interview lasting 25 minutes, and the lengthiest interview lasting one hour and 20 minutes.

Participants

The methods used to find and recruit participants for a qualitative study are important for controlling bias and efficiently procuring a representative sample (Arcury & Quandt, 1999). To select participants, I used purposeful sampling, with criterion sampling as the specific strategy. According to Patton (2002), “the logic of criterion sampling is to review and study all cases that meet some predetermined criterion of importance, a strategy common in quality assurance efforts” (p. 238).

Qualitative samples must be sizable enough to assure that most or all the observations that could be valuable are uncovered. However, if the sample is too large, the data may become redundant and eventually unnecessary. Purposeful sampling seeks to understand and illuminate important cases rather than generalizing from a sample to a population (Patton, 2002). This technique is commonly used in qualitative research to identify and select information-rich cases that will provide depth and detail. Palinkas et al. (2015) noted that “from the perspective of qualitative methodology, participants who meet or exceed a specific criterion or criteria possess intimate (or, at the very least, greater) knowledge of the phenomena of interest by virtue of their experience, making them information-rich cases” (p. 539).

Purposeful sampling assumes that the investigator wants to discover, understand, and gain insight into the study topic (Leedy & Ormrod, 2016). Therefore, it requires selecting a sample from which the most can be learned (Merriam & Tisdell, 2015). For example, to research how companies were organized and managed, Peters and Waterman (1982) used a purposeful sample of 62 U.S. companies considered by an informed group of business observers to be innovative and excellent.

People unfamiliar with purposeful sampling may view this method as biased. However, qualitative sampling typically focuses on relatively small samples selected purposefully to permit in-depth inquiry and understanding of a phenomenon (Patton, 2002). With qualitative sampling, bias cannot be measured or controlled, and data results cannot be generalized (Acharya et al., 2013). In analytical generalization, the researcher generalizes a set of results to develop a more expansive theory (Yin, 2017).

However, in qualitative research, the aim is to find meaning and not make generalized hypotheses (Mason, 2010). Quantitative methods typically depend on larger samples selected randomly to allow researchers to generalize with confidence from the sample to the population it represents (Patton, 2002). Ultimately, the study results must be understood within the context of the organization(s) and, perhaps, the geographical area in which the fieldwork was carried out. To assess the extent to which findings may be true of participants in other sites, similar projects employing the same methods but conducted in different environments could have significant value (Shenton, 2004). Whether the methodology is quantitative or qualitative, sampling methods are intended to increase efficiency and validity (Palinkas et al., 2015).

For this study, I chose a department within the institution that serves students, faculty, and staff. I serve as a volunteer board member at this institution. I was virtually introduced to the

head of the department, and he agreed to participate in the study. I had no previous relationship with the head of this department.

Staff at the institution are reviewed annually using a performance evaluation form (see Appendix A). The *University Handbook* (2018) states:

the supervisor/manager shall evaluate all staff employees in a systematic manner at specified time intervals, but no less than once each year. An employee within their provisional period should be evaluated at least once prior to the completion of the provisional period. (p. 32)

The participants were all beyond their six-month provisional period. Provisional periods typically precede regular employment contracts and are commonly interpreted as a screening device for employers. During provisional periods, employers learn about worker quality without committing to the binding rules of a formal employment contract (Riphahn & Thalmaier, 2001). While there is no law determining the length of a provisional period, it is typical for a provisional period to last no longer than six months, and three months when an employee moves to a new post internally (Buck, 2014).

The performance evaluation includes dimensions for leadership and initiative. The leadership dimension is further defined as motivation, direction, and task-goal orientation. In addition to assessing performance dimensions that include job knowledge and teamwork, the evaluation also includes assessing initiative in the section for Individual Responsibility (See Appendix A). Though I did not have access to the participants' evaluations, the evaluations are relevant as they highlight the elements of the construct studied and provided a basis for an essential aspect of the procedural portion of this study.

Participant Selection

IRB approval was received in February 2020. After IRB approval, a letter with detailed instructions was sent to the department head. The letter described what was being studied, what the study was designed to discover, why the letter's recipient was selected as a potential participant, the research benefit, and the school information for the research (see Appendix B for Manager's Invitation Letter).

Exhibiting personal initiative means being self-starting, proactive, and persistent in the face of barriers (Frese & Fay, 2001). The department head was instructed to select multiple employees based on the attributes outlined for personal initiative. The department head was asked to select a mix of individuals: those who highly demonstrated personal initiative, those who did not exhibit the behavior at all, and those who fell in the middle. As the department head evaluates employees annually using an evaluation form that includes direction, goal-orientation, and initiative, he had a foundation to select employees. The department head was also asked to indicate how long he has supervised each individual.

On March 12, 2020, I received an Excel spreadsheet from the department head that listed all 31 employees in the department. The spreadsheet included the department head's notations regarding how each employee demonstrated personal initiative, their number of years with the institution, and their email addresses. As participants in this study were university employees affected by the day-to-day changes resulting from COVID-19, I was concerned about reaching out to them about participating in a research study. I shared my concerns with the department head on March 22, 2020 and included a link to IRB guidance. The department head felt that I could continue my research online. He offered to send an email message to all employees (see Appendix C for department head email) advising them that they might be contacted by someone

connected to the institution currently pursuing a UGA doctoral degree. This message specified that participation in the study was completely voluntary.

I selected a mix of employees from the list based on their demonstrated personal initiative levels and the number of years the department head had worked with the employee. I sent invitations to 16 employees. Selected employees were sent an email with a participation letter (see Appendix D) containing information about the study and a consent form (see Appendix E). Of the 16 invitations sent, eight employees responded and returned their consent forms. I then followed up with these employees with calendar invitations to schedule interviews.

Eight of the 16 employees did not respond to the invitation to participate in the research study. Of the eight employees who did not respond, the department head rated six individuals as demonstrating high personal initiative. Two individuals were rated by the department head as not demonstrating personal initiative at all. Of the 31 employees in the department, 15 (48%) of the employees were rated as highly demonstrating PI, eight (26%) were rated as not demonstrating PI at all, and eight (26%) were rated as falling in the middle.

Participant Demographics

This study's participant group included four individuals who identified as female and four who identified as male. Three of the study participants identified as Black, one as multiracial, and four as White. The length of time participants had worked for the institution ranged from two to 30 years. Two of the participants were rated by the department head as demonstrating high personal initiative. One was rated as not demonstrating personal initiative at all. Five were rated as demonstrating personal initiative that fell in the middle range.

Data Collection

The purpose of gathering data in qualitative research is to provide evidence for the experience it is investigating (Polkinghorne, 2005). Qualitative research seeks to develop a multifaceted picture of the problem or issue under study. Therefore, it involves reporting multiple perspectives and recognizing the many factors involved in a situation (Creswell, 2014).

The purpose of this research was to explore how employees perceived the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement; therefore, interviews were the primary method of data collection. Qualitative interviewing starts with the notion that others' perspectives are meaningful, knowable, and can be seen clearly (Patton, 2002). Interviewing serves as a primary way to direct the participant in responding to a specific research question (Stuckey, 2013).

Dworkin (2012) noted that “while some experts in qualitative research avoid the topic of how many interviews are ‘enough,’ there is indeed variability in what is suggested as a minimum” (p. 1319). If the objective is to describe a shared perception, belief, or behavior among a relatively similar group, a sample of 12 will likely be enough (Guest et al., 2006). Data saturation is the point in the research process at which no new information is discovered in the data analysis. Data saturation lets the researcher know that data collection can come to an end (Faulkner & Trotter, 2017).

The sample for this study did not reach 12. The information that emerged from the eighth and final participant did not present new information, and I did not pursue additional potential participants to interview. In a qualitative study, there are no set rules for the size of a sample. The study's purpose determines sample size, what is valuable, what will have credibility, and the time and resources available (Patton, 2002).

There are several forms of interviews, including open-ended, focused, structured, semi-structured, and survey. A semi-structured approach was used in this study, and interview questions were developed from the initial research questions. In a semi-structured interview, the researcher creates an outline for the topics to be covered, but the interviewees' responses determine how the interview is directed (Stuckey, 2013).

Responses to semi-structured interview questions tend to be in narrative form in the respondents' own words. The interviewer needs to develop skills to diagnose why an answer is incomplete and learn an array of nondirective probes that will elicit the needed information (Lewis-Beck et al., 2003). Gathering responses to open-ended questions enables researchers to understand and capture respondents' points of view without predetermining those perspectives through the prior selection of questionnaire categories (Patton, 2015). Open-ended responses permit researchers to understand the world, as seen by respondents (Grinnell & Unrau, 2010).

Frese et al. (1997) recommended a situational approach in measuring personal initiative, in their case using a situational interview (Latham & Saari, 1984), and cautioned against measuring personal initiative solely with traditional self-report scales. An approach is situational when it facilitates flexibility and adaptiveness. Situational approaches incorporate techniques that enable researchers to detect and respond to contingencies and the emergence of surprising case data (Pan & Tan, 2011).

As interviews were the data collection method, notes were taken as part of the collection process, and an interview guide was used. Taking notes is beneficial because qualitative research designs have an emergent nature. Notes are unique to the researcher and help to evaluate what insights to pursue or not pursue (Muzwasi & Nhamo, 2013). An interview guide is a mechanism to help the interviewer conduct an effective semi-structured interview. It can take various forms,

but the principal consideration is that it allows the interviewer to ask questions relevant to the research focus (Mason, 2004). I used a question-based guide. With a question-based guide, there is the ability to suggest probes and follow-up questions that expound on the initial set of questions (Morgan & Guevara, 2008).

Suter (2011) noted that “qualitative data collection and analysis usually happen simultaneously. Ongoing findings affect what types of data are collected and how they are collected” (p. 346). When researchers review interview notes, they interpret those notes and consider their reaction to the notes. This process offers a way to develop and outline the analytic process and encourages ongoing conceptualization (Flick, 2013).

Data analysis occurs as part of the note review process. With an interview guide approach, responses from various participants can be grouped based on topics from the guide. When carefully constructed, an interview guide can provide a descriptive framework for analysis (Patton, 2002; see Appendix F).

Probing can be an important tool for safeguarding the reliability of the data. It allows the researcher to elicit greater detail regarding interesting and relevant issues and clarify inconsistencies within respondents’ accounts (Hutchinson & Wilson, 1992). Knight (2013) identified the following probes or conversation continuers that help facilitate an interview:

- Can you give me an example of what you mean?
- Please tell me more about that.
- What you are sharing (or have said) is important. Can you say more?
- How does your experience before that time compare to your experience now?
- Tell me more about that experience (or that time)?
- How do you see that (or yourself) in the future?

- If you could change anything about that experience, what would it be? (p. 3)

Throughout the interview process, probes were a valuable tool to prompt participants to provide additional information.

Collection Methods

All participants signed and returned the participant consent form, which included the information that the interviews would be recorded. At the start of each interview, I asked the participant again if they gave their permission to record the interview. I interviewed seven of the participants via Zoom “peer-to-peer” video and interviewed one participant by phone, with no video. I used Otter.ai to record the audio for that participant. Otter.ai turns audio voice conversations into smart notes. The data is synced over an encrypted connection and stored in a secure data center with physical and electronic security (Otter.ai, 2020).

A recording has the advantage of providing an interview report that is more accurate than writing out notes. Recording the interviews makes it easier for the researcher to focus on the interview content and verbal prompts and enables the transcriptionist to generate a verbatim transcript of the interview (Jamshed, 2014). However, recording also introduces the danger of not taking *any* notes during the interview. Taking notes during the interview is vital for the interviewer (even if the interview is recorded) for the following reasons: (a) to check whether all of the questions have been answered, (b) as a backup in case of a recorder malfunction, and (c) as a backup in case of an interviewer “malfunction” (like forgetting to turn on the recorder) (Opdenakker, 2006).

In taking notes, it is important to distinguish between actual observations and impressions. A researcher must separate fact (what the researcher sees and hears) from opinion (what the researcher thinks might be going on) (Leedy & Ormrod, 2016). For this study, I took

notes during each interview and highlighted interesting insights when I read through the notes. Recording and tracking analytical insights during data collection are part of fieldwork and mark the beginning of qualitative analysis (Patton, 2002).

Data Analysis

I used Otter.ai to transcribe audio from each interview into a Microsoft Word document for coding. Though transcription attempts to provide a verbatim account, errors can occur. A common type of error involves the misinterpretation or mishearing of a word by the software. Such a change in even one word can alter the entire meaning of the phrase and result in missing key themes (Easton et al., 2000). Having the audio file for each interview allowed me to listen to each interview, correct transcription errors, and take additional notes.

There are many types of software tools available to analyze data. Qualitative software programs have become quite popular for helping researchers organize, sort, and search for information in text or image databases (Creswell, 2014). I researched the HyperRESEARCH, NVivo, ATLAS.ti, and MAXQDA platforms as part of a class assignment and initially thought I would use NVivo. My former employer offered NVivo for free, but I would have had to return to the worksite to have it installed. I decided not to have it installed as I was potentially exposed to an infected co-worker at the start of the COVID-19 crisis. I did not want to risk exposure for the sake of the installation, and I also recognized that if I did obtain the software, it would involve a learning curve. Learning the basics of coding while simultaneously trying to figure out the multifaceted functions of a coding software program can be overwhelming for some, if not most, researchers (Saldaña, 2016). The idea behind NVivo is to make it easier to analyze qualitative data (Jackson & Bazeley, 2019). However, this intention is to a larger extent defeated if we consider the how time consuming and difficult it might be to learn how to use the software

(Zamawe 2015). Ose (2016) noted that “computer assisted qualitative data analysis software is too advanced and sophisticated when all we want is to sort and structure text” (p.147). CAQDAS packages *aid* in the analysis process, they do not analyze the data. The researcher is in control of that process (Zamawe, 2015). For a larger study, CAQDAS software would be more appropriate. For this study, I chose to use Microsoft Word and Excel to code the transcribed interview data because I was familiar with both software packages and could spend more time analyzing data versus learning a new software tool.

Coding

The process of qualitative data analysis is reflexive and iterative. It begins as data is being collected rather than after the data collection process has ended (Stake, 1995). The final product is shaped by the data collected and the analysis that accompanies the entire process. Merriam and Tisdell (2015) reflected that “without ongoing analysis, the data can be unfocused, repetitious, and overwhelming in the sheer volume of material that needs to be processed” (p. 197). To preclude such concerns, I reviewed my notes during the initial data analysis after each interview, highlighted areas of interest, and looked for repetition.

The coding process involves aggregating the text or visual data into small categories of information, seeking evidence from different databases, then assigning a label to the information (Creswell, 2013). *Data reduction* involves deciding which chunks of data will be pulled out and coded. Data reduction is not separate from analysis; it is part of the analysis. The researcher’s decisions regarding which data chunks to code, which to pull out, and which evolving stories to tell are all analytic choices (Namey et al., 2007). This process is significant because not all information collected can be used in a qualitative study.

Saldaña (2016) outlined a multitude of coding methods that include initial and in vivo, among others. These are the two coding methods I relied on for analysis. For nearly all qualitative studies, using initial coding is appropriate. *Initial coding* is a starting point. Codes that emerge during this phase of analysis are not final and may even be reworded during the coding process (Saldaña, 2016). I started the initial coding process by reading each interview and highlighting chunks of the participant responses, using the comments section in Microsoft Word to code the data.

As the purpose of this research was to explore how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement, in vivo coding was an applicable coding method. *In vivo coding* focuses on words that come from the actual language found in the data and is appropriate for studies that honor and prioritize the voices of the participants (Saldaña, 2016).

After the eight interview transcripts were coded, I copied the comments from each of the interviews into a Microsoft Excel file. I organized the codes by each participant in one tab and used another tab to compile all codes. I compiled over 440 unique codes in this tab. To further reduce this data, I sorted and filtered the codes to see which codes were similar. I highlighted similar codes, then organized similar codes into categories. As Morse (2008) explained, “basically, a category is a collection of similar data sorted into the same place, and this arrangement enables the researchers to identify and describe the characteristics of the category” (p. 727).

I also created a participant observation summary for each interview. Presenting this information in a table is helpful when there are multiple participants in a study. A simple table shows a summary paragraph of each participant’s primary data in one column, with major codes

in another column (Saldaña, 2016). Table 1 offers an example of one of the participant observation summaries I completed for this study.

Table 1

Example of Participant Observation Summary

Katie	Going forward on your own Picking up my game Learning on your own Stepping up Customer service Lifetime learning	For this participant, personal initiative means being a self-starter, taking care of things without being told, and looking to solve problems before they become problems. This participant hopes to be a lifetime learner. She enjoys learning new things and new technologies and having the knowledge to become better at everything she does. She defined career achievement as learning new things and being appreciated for being very good at her job. She enjoys learning new things and also noted that career achievement meant passing on knowledge to other people.
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After I developed categories from the coded data, I started to see themes emerging from the categories. Saldaña (2016) noted, “like coding, thematic analysis or the search for themes in the data is a strategic choice as part of the research design that includes primary questions, goals, conceptual framework, and literature review” (p. 200).

Validation

In qualitative research, coding’s impact is to aggregate the data into a small number of themes (Creswell, 2013) that will function as attributes, descriptors, elements, and concepts (Ayres et al., 2003). After the data was analyzed and themes emerged, it was necessary to validate the data. Miller (2008) noted that “in the field of research, validity refers broadly to the ‘goodness’ or ‘soundness’ of a study” (p.910). A limitation of any study design or instrument is the systematic bias that the researcher did not or could not control, which could inappropriately affect the results (Price & Murnan, 2004). *Bias* is any trend or deviation from the truth in data collection, data analysis, interpretation, or publication that can lead to false conclusions.

Instrumentation rigor and bias management are significant challenges for qualitative researchers employing interviewing as a data generation method in their studies (Chenail, 2011).

Bias can occur either deliberately or inadvertently (Simundic, 2013). As participants go through the study, they may discuss the questions asked by the interviewer. Bias could lead to answering questions in a way they believe might please the researcher. *Response bias* is a generic term for a range of responses to interviews, surveys, or questionnaires. Responses result from bias instead of an effort to be correct, honest, and accurate (Furnham, 1986). *Social desirability* refers to the tendency to deny undesirable traits, claim socially desirable ones, and say things that place one in a favorable light (Nederhof, 1985). Participants may try to answer in a positive manner that validates their selection for the study.

A benefit of the interview method is that it lets the researcher control the line of questioning. However, this can also be a disadvantage because the researcher's presence can bias responses (Creswell, 2014). Validity, therefore, must always be considered throughout the qualitative research process. Lincoln and Guba (1985) proposed four criteria for judging the soundness of qualitative research and explicitly offered them as alternatives to more traditional, quantitatively oriented criteria:

Credibility is the "truth" of the findings, as viewed through the eyes of those being observed or interviewed. *Transferability* is the extent to which findings can be transferred to other settings. *Dependability* is the extent to which the research would produce similar or consistent findings if carried out as described, including considering any factors that may have affected the research results. *Confirmability* refers to the degree to which others could substantiate the results. Such evidence should come directly from subjects and research context, rather than the researcher's biases, motivations, or perspectives. (p. 290)

Validation must occur throughout the data collection and data analysis processes. Internal validity seeks to ensure that a study measures or explores its intent (Shenton, 2004). Peer scrutiny of the research project and member checking are methods of achieving internal validity (Shenton, 2004). *Peer reviewers* can provide support, play devil's advocate, challenge the researcher's assumptions, encourage the researcher to advance to the next step methodologically, and ask the tough questions regarding methods as well as interpretations (Creswell & Miller, 2000).

Peer Debriefing

I chose three transcripts to send to peer reviewers, including the longest interview, the shortest interview, and an interview that fell between the two in terms of length. I sent a request to peers with information that included a description of my topic and a peer debriefing definition. In *peer debriefing*, a researcher shares work with peers who are impartial and asks them to question the researcher's work in a method that is consistent and logical (Henry, 2015). All my peer reviewers are University of Georgia doctoral students in the Mary Frances Early College of Education. My peer reviewers were Luke Hearn, doctoral candidate, Workforce Education; Marques Dexter, doctoral candidate, Sport Management & Policy; and Sally Robertson, doctoral student, Workforce Education.

When peers responded to my message indicating they would serve, I followed up with an email that included the peer debrief instructions. Reviewers were provided with the transcript of the interviews with my codes. Each peer reviewer read one transcript. All descriptive information about the participant was removed from the transcript before being forwarded to reviewers. The participant summary was included at the end of the transcript. Peers were asked not to read the summary until they had made their notations.

Peers were given one week to review the transcript and forward notes to the researcher. Peer debriefers may assist in refining and questioning researcher assumptions as they start to make sense of the data. Peer debriefers contribute to the credibility of a study's findings, analyses, and conclusions (Nguyễn, 2008). The notes from my peers were insightful, and the questions they asked concurred with notations I had made regarding possibilities for future research. Peers saw the data with new eyes, and their notations helped me clarify some codes for categorization.

Member Checking

Participants can act as judges, evaluating the significant findings of a study (Denzin, 1978). *Member checking* is also an essential part of this process to authenticate the data. Member checking provides an opportunity for participants to approve aspects of the researchers' interpretation of what they presented (Doyle, 2007; Merriam, 1998). Member checking is a way of discovering whether the data analysis is consistent with the participants' experiences (Curtin & Fossey, 2007). Checking with participants to make sure the analysis has captured what those participants intended authenticates the research. As Birt et al. (2016) noted:

the credibility of member checking rests not in the “doing” of the procedure, but in the reporting of the outcomes, for it is only through good quality reporting that others can make judgments about whether the methods have enhanced the credibility of the results. (p. 1809)

However, there are also drawbacks to the member checking process. The interview process may have influenced a participant's original assessment, or new experiences may have intervened. Respondents may disagree with the researcher's interpretation, raising the question of whose interpretation should stand (Angen, 2000).

Before using member checking, researchers must be clear on the relevance and value of the method within their design and consider whether they have the resources to undertake further analysis if participants disagree (Birt et al., 2016). Creswell (2014) emphasized that member checking is best done with polished interpreted fragments such as themes and patterns emerging from the data versus the actual transcripts. Carlson (2010) advised that traps can unknowingly be set during member checking. These traps may threaten the researcher/participant relationship and possibly the stability of the study.

In the present study, each participant was informed that they would not receive a verbatim copy of their interview transcript as part of the interview process. Participants received an observation summary of their interview. I created a form for participants to report if they had any additional information to add to their interview summary. Questions on the form were adapted from Birt et al.'s (2016) Synthesized Member Checking (SMC) flowchart. The form also asked the participant if the summary matched their interview experience (see Appendix G). I included demographic information on the form to confirm the participants' race and gender, based on their responses about their identities, not my observation. All eight participants completed the form. None of the participants had additions to their interviews, and all participants affirmed that the summary matched their interview experience.

Subjectivity Statement

An additional way to increase validity in qualitative research is for the researcher to identify the biases and personal issues that may influence their inquiry (Creswell & Miller, 2000). The researcher is at the center of the entire process and thus introduces a range of strategic, ethical, and personal issues into the qualitative research process (Locke et al., 2014).

Measures that address internal and external validity throughout the research process help to reduce these issues.

I started working when I was 16. Working was not for *extra* money; it was to have necessities. I lost my mother 20 days before I turned 15, so earning money to pay for lunch at school and buy new clothes was my responsibility. Very early, I learned that self-direction, proactivity, and persistence in the face of barriers were necessary skills for survival. It was also important to me never to use the loss of my mother as an excuse for failure. Being self-starting has been an essential part of my personal and professional journey, and personal initiative has inspired my interest in this study.

Any credible research strategy requires the investigator to adopt a neutral stance with respect to the phenomenon under study (Patton, 2002). However, qualitative researchers recognize that their values cannot be entirely omitted from the research experience. They acknowledge the value-laden nature of the experience by recognizing and discussing their own biases and the implications of those biases for their findings (Creswell, 2014).

I am mindful of personal perceptions and therefore used peer scrutiny throughout the data collection and analysis processes. The fresh perspectives that peers bring allow them to challenge the researcher's assumptions. Peer questions and observations allow researchers to refine their methods, develop a more significant explanation of the research design, and strengthen their arguments (Shenton, 2004).

Summary

This chapter described the design, site, sample selection, data collection, and data analysis methods used in the study. Throughout data analysis, the researcher pursued a path of analyzing the data to obtain a more detailed knowledge of the topic being studied (Creswell,

2013). The chapter also detailed the coding methods and validation approaches employed in the research. The themes that emerged from the data analysis described in this chapter will be presented in Chapter 4.

CHAPTER 4

PRESENTATION OF FINDINGS

The purpose of this study was to explore how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. The researcher sought to examine and describe perceptions of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement among employees at a higher education institution in the Southeast. The first three chapters of this dissertation identified personal initiative as one of the top skills employers seek, and college graduates lack when entering the workforce, reviewed previous research that provides a framework for understanding personal initiative, and outlined the methodological design used for this study. A basic qualitative design was used to guide this research and answer the following questions:

1. How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?
2. How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?
3. How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

This chapter presents the study's findings, which describe the participants' perceptions of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. In their interviews, participants responded to 12 semi-structured interview questions (see Appendix F) developed from the three main research questions. I addressed and analyzed each research question through a list of the participants' responses to the interview questions. During the qualitative research process, the researcher concentrates on discovering the meanings participants hold concerning the issue, not the meaning the researcher brings to the research (Creswell, 2013). The chapter includes a brief

vignette of each participant, findings for each research question, and common themes that emerged from the participant interviews.

Participant Vignettes

Each of the eight participants in this study was assigned a pseudonym to maintain anonymity. Each participant vignette is based on responses to questions about their careers and participants' responses to the semi-structured interview questions. These vignettes are brief excerpts and not full participant profiles.

Providing a detailed description of participants can be difficult, as “for qualitative researchers, maintaining respondent confidentiality while presenting rich, detailed accounts of social life presents unique challenges” (Kaiser, 2009, p. 1632). The department is small (31 employees) and giving too much demographic information might allow individuals to be identified. Vignettes are presented in the same order in which participants were interviewed.

Amina

Amina is Black and identifies as female. She is a technical design professional. Amina noted that she first experienced personal initiative as a little girl. She described herself as a creative individual and remarked that personal initiative is the “lifeblood” of what she does.

Amina was a first-generation college student. Throughout her interview, she talked about the guidance her mother gave her about the work world. She stated:

My mom definitely taught me I have to be more prepared. My mom was very honest with me about her experiences at her job and the things that she went through. That was always in my mind before I started working.

When she faced a barrier of pay disparity at work, Amina said she spoke up because her mother never could. Amina shared that her mother did not feel that she could speak up about things that she experienced at work.

Daughtrey

Daughtrey is White and identifies as male. He is a database support professional.

Daughtrey noted that he first experienced personal initiative at age 28 and shared how important it was to be proactive in terms of training to learn emerging technologies. He related:

It was certainly a lot later than I would have hoped. You know, if I have to recall, coming out of college, I had jobs that paid between \$30,000 and \$40,000 a year, and there was little if any opportunity to advance to a role where I was making more. . . . Once I found myself at my current university, there was that opportunity. I mean, it was just cause and effect. I would learn something new, get a raise or promotion. So once that started happening, it was really easy for me to find the energy to take that kind of initiative because I was able to see a palpable increase in my income.

Katie

Katie is White and identifies as female. She is an information security professional. Katie was also a first-generation college student and noted that she first experienced personal initiative in the middle of college. She talked about being on her own and being self-reliant, as her family was not in the same geographic location. “I really had to pick up my game to get anything done because I didn’t have them here to be able to rely on to do things for me.”

I asked Katie what she drew upon to step up her game, and she told me she was not sure how to answer but thought it was *just a necessity*. At another point in the interview, I told Katie I noticed her body language open up when we talked about learning new things. She shared that

she hoped she would always be a lifetime learner. “I really enjoy learning new things. I enjoy, you know, learning new technologies, and just having that knowledge. Hopefully, it helps me become better at everything I do.”

Wen

Wen is White and identifies as male. He is a network support paraprofessional. Wen reported that he first experienced personal initiative as a teenager in his first job. He stated:

I had to be very dependable in order to keep that job, and I had to balance being nice with being fast . . . They call it courtesy, accuracy, and productivity. I had to have all three to make that job work. I had to really be on time and attentive.

Coming through is important to Wen, as evidenced by the fact that it came up five times during his interview. Wen indicated that he would stay late to assist a colleague without being asked. Wen also shared that he is willing to stop what he is doing to come through for a colleague when a problem arises. Wen talked about his initiative, recalling an instance in which he saw a problem with the system and came to work on a Sunday so the team could have a head start before the workweek began.

Soleia

Soleia is multiracial and identifies as female. She is an application support professional. Soleia indicated that she first experienced personal initiative in high school. She expressed:

You’re definitely given multiple opportunities to look at different aspects of your future and how to improve or grow. You’re kind of forced into that decision-making time period as to what you want to do, you know? I think everybody kind of has that point in time when they’re like, how do I want to better myself?

For Soleia, personal initiative meant volunteering for tasks not necessarily directly assigned to her. “I haven’t seen an opportunity where I could volunteer and be like, I don’t think this is gonna help me in any way, form, or fashion. I also think every experience, you know, you learn from.”

Alexis

Alexis is Black and identifies as female. She is a network support paraprofessional. Alexis was a first-generation college student and shared that she first experienced personal initiative when she was 24. She volunteered to be the onsite person during an event projected to cause significant computer-related issues. Alexis explained she took the time to do research and figured out a disaster recovery plan. She stated:

I put myself out there; I was nervous and a little unsure of myself. I will be honest about that, but it turned out to be really fun and a really good learning experience dealing with technology. . .Systems go down, and you know, things happen. It taught me you can’t prepare for everything. It did teach me how not to panic.

Joseph

Joseph is Black and identifies as male. Joseph is a client support professional and was also a first-generation college student. Joseph indicated that he first experienced personal initiative when he was six. He explained that he was curious and wanted to know how things worked. Joseph stated:

One day I was really curious about the remote-control car I had, and I took it apart just because I wanted to know how it functions. I was like wow, cool, and I put it back together, and it didn’t work. Instead of just going to my [parent] and saying, hey, my car’s not working anymore, I need a new one—no, I continued every day, taking it apart,

putting it back together, seeing what this did, what this didn't do. Until eventually, honestly, I don't know how long it took, I worked on that car until I got it back working.

Apollo

Apollo is White and identifies as male. He is an audiovisual technical paraprofessional. Apollo shared that he first experienced personal initiative when he was 20 or 21. He said he could not point to a specific event but noted that he started to ask questions when things did not seem right. Apollo indicated that if something was not working correctly, he desired to get it fixed, so it was working again. Apollo said being proactive gives him a feeling of satisfaction. "I take a little bit more pleasure in my work when I know that I am helping to fix problems."

Research Question Findings

The result of the coding process is a theme (Saldaña, 2016). Common themes emerged throughout the interview process. According to Rubin and Rubin (2012), "themes are statements *qua* (in the role of) ideas presented by participants during interviews that summarize what is going on, explain what is happening, or suggest why something is done the way it is" (p. 118). The researcher analyzed responses to the semi-structured interview questions. This synthesis produced themes directly related to the main research questions. Findings from each of the three research questions are presented in the next section.

Findings for Research Question 1

Research Question 1 was, "How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?" Findings for this question were obtained by collecting and analyzing transcribed interview data and notes taken during the interviews. The findings for Research Question 1 indicated that the participants perceived personal initiative in various ways. Themes emerging

from Research Question 1 included being self-starting, proactive, self-directed as a learner, and committed to the team. Sample quotes illustrating how participants perceived personal initiative are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2

Research Question 1: Participants' Perceptions of Personal Initiative

Theme	Example Quote
Self-Starting	"Taking personal initiative, that is the lifeblood of what I do, both creatively and professional . . . You also have to be self-disciplined and self-trained, constantly evolving with the technology depending on your discipline and keeping your skills fresh. Your portfolio fresh. So honestly, whether it's for a client or myself, I have to have initiative 24/7 to be able to do what I do." (Amina)
Being Proactive	"I guess probably mostly it would be doing things myself instead of waiting to be told to do them, and when I see something that needs to be worked on, going ahead and starting to work with it or contacting people about it, or whatever needs to be done, and not just letting it sit there." (Apollo)
Self-Starting	"Being a self-starter [means] taking initiative to take care of things without being told to take care of [them], looking to solve problems before they become problems." (Katie)
Being Proactive	"I think the simplest way I think of it as just volunteering when tasks are, I guess not necessarily . . . waiting until they are assigned . . . you know, a lot of times your supervisor will say, 'Hey, I got X, Y and Z,' and it might not be exactly related to your job description or title . . . I feel like . . . just hey, do I have any takers, and then just kind of proactively being, 'Yeah, sure, I could do that,' you know, and being that person to really take charge . . ." (Soleia)

Table 2 (continued)*Research Question 1: Participants' Perceptions of Personal Initiative*

Theme	Example Quote
Self-Starting	"To me, personal initiative is all about one's self-starting something. So, um, do they take it upon themselves to go and do something that needs to get done, or that wasn't getting done, or do they sit around and wait for someone to say, hey, X, Y and Z needs to happen?" (Joseph)
Self-Directed Learning	"IT is a field that people in my field are currently actively defining. Um, I feel it is a little unique that if I don't take initiative to keep myself current, I become obsolete, um, in an almost unfair amount of time . . . To me it means being proactive as far as training . . . yeah, just making sure you're getting extra training on new systems and emerging technologies." (Daughtrey)
Team Commitment	"Well, it's, you got to be there for people, you got to be up and ready to go. Ready to help when you're needed. When people are counting on you to be there, you've got to be there . . . You know, if you're supposed to be at work at a certain time, you need to be there at that time . . . you need to keep your promises with regards to being able to help people. Sometimes it does mean going the extra mile, you know, you have some unexpected stuff come up, and you've got to help out in unusual or different ways." (Wen)
Being Proactive	"I feel that it is looking at the whole picture and then trying to find solutions that will not just solve one issue that might arise, but instead kind of looking outside the box, so that you can plan ahead and look for something that might not have presented itself at that time, but in the future, it could be something that comes up, and it's like, oh goodness, okay, well, we prepared early enough. So now we have this available, we didn't use it before, but we have it available." (Alexis)

Katie shared that she enjoyed learning, and several participants discussed taking the initiative to learn on their own. As these participants work with evolving technology, several also mentioned that they often faced the obstacle of not knowing how to do something and having to teach themselves. Joseph mentioned first starting in his role and reaching a stopping point in his training. Unable to move on to the next section, he asked for additional projects. Joseph said,

“Well, if I’m gonna sit back here, I want to learn something. What can I do while I am back here since I have to stay in this area for X amount of time?” Joseph’s superiors would let him go over to another area when he came to work, and Joseph recalled that he would soak up whatever he could. He noted that those small projects he worked on ended up being guides and procedures for the department.

The Disadvantages of Displaying Personal Initiative

While participants in this study identified advantages of displaying personal initiative, including personal growth, and being seen as a valuable employee, another finding regarding participant perceptions of personal initiative was an understanding that there were also disadvantages to displaying personal initiative. When I asked about some of these disadvantages, Katie replied, “sometimes people think you could be pushy, or maybe think that you are overstepping your bounds . . . that perhaps you should have come to them before you made a decision to go forward and fix something.”

Apollo identified a disadvantage as the risk that things could begin to be routed to the wrong channels if you help with something that is outside your regular work role. He noted that people might think you are the person to go to all the time. Soleia discussed potentially getting overwhelmed and not being able to follow through, stating:

At one point, maybe you’re overwhelmed if you don’t necessarily see what you agreed to, or what you signed up for. The uncertainties or the anomalies in the process after you have volunteered. Volunteering is always a good thing, but then actually following through is another aspect of it.

Amina commented that in a professional team setting, not everyone displays personal initiative at the same level. According to DuBrin (2013), “coworkers who are not proactive may feel threatened by proactive employees who frequently push for change” (p. 67). Amina shared:

I’ve definitely experienced situations where I took extra initiative in a task in things and maybe a colleague did not and might perceive that as calling attention to what they may or may not be doing. So that is one of the pitfalls, you kind of have to balance it depending on the environment you’re in [and] depending on the different colleagues that you have.

Joseph observed that he appreciated people who displayed personal initiative and noted that he had encountered individuals who were overly eager to gain experience but lacked knowledge or proper understanding.

From the findings in Research Question 1, it can be understood that these participants do not wait to be told to do something if they see a need for a solution. They are proactive, and when they do not know how to do something, they take it upon themselves to learn. Participants perceived personal initiative as being self-starting, proactive, self-directed as learners, and committed to the team. For the participants in this study, being there and being counted on is also part of how they perceive personal initiative. Team commitment is a theme that arose from the responses across all three interview questions.

Findings for Research Question 2

Research Question 2 was, “How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?” The findings for Research Question 2 indicated that the participants experienced personal initiative in the workplace in various ways. Themes that emerged from Research Question 2 included being proactive, taking initiative, finding solutions to problems, and being

self-directed as learners. Examples of how participants experienced personal initiative in the workplace are outlined in Table 3.

Table 3

Research Question 2: Ways Participants Have Experienced PI in the Workplace

Theme	Example Quote
Being Proactive	“If I see a problem that could be done better, even if it’s not requested, if I can fix it or if I can improve it, I try to. . . Any time I see an area for improvement or something that can benefit the department, I’ve brought it to my manager.” (Amina)
Taking Initiative	“I took a lot of initiative because . . . I worked at the library as electronics assistant back then, a few years ago, and just proactively assessing the equipment and, you know, where the [department] should be going within the next five years as far as technology goes, because that’s always, you know, libraries and technology is a necessity in a way.” (Soleia)
Being Proactive	“I don’t like to be idle, so I will find stuff that needs to be looked at or addressed around our site . . . If I don’t start a project, I’ll get some people together and get them to talking about it, and then they’ll start the project on their own.” (Joseph)
Problem Solving	“One of the barriers that I had when I first got into this position . . . there wasn’t a real understanding of hey, this guy knows . . . there wasn’t a trust level, the trust level wasn’t there between other divisions of our department and myself . . . I was trying to inform our networking department that, hey . . . there’s a disconnect. Well, [the department] told me, ‘I don’t think you know what you’re talking about. There’s nothing wrong with the network. There’s no settings that are wrong.’ Essentially, I had to figure out how to do my entire job by getting around this point of our network. It took some time, and I had to go in and show them step-by-step facts of this is why your network is wrong . . . I asked for X, you told me I didn’t need X, I’m telling you, the company says you need X in order for this to work.” (Joseph)

Table 3 (continued)

Research Question 2: Ways Participants have experienced PI in the Workplace

Theme	Example Quote
Problem Solving	“So, it’s relatively common for me to face a boundary of not having the knowledge to do something . . . Google and YouTube are my friends in that endeavor, big time . . . you know, you just cannot throw your hands up in that situation. You just have to figure it out . . . You know, maybe I’ve gotten lucky along the years. I can’t think of a situation where I was stuck on something and to this day, I’m still stuck . . . If I get stuck, there’s always another way.” (Daughtrey)
Self-Directed Learning	“That different way of doing it was a little learning curve. It took me a couple of weeks to kind of really get my feet like okay, this is how we are doing it. Once got over that, I guess that was more so a barrier of mind, I really immersed myself in understanding.” (Alexis)

Interpersonal Competence

Another finding regarding the way participants experienced personal initiative in the workplace related to interpersonal competence. Amina is an adaptive, collaborative member of the team and is sensitive to others’ ideas, even when they have not presented them in the most effective way. Amina believes that even if the end product of a creative idea that someone put forth looks nothing like the original concept, the essence of their contribution should stay intact. She expressed:

A lot of times, I am in a position where I have to hold hands and help guide them on the proper way to develop what they want in their mind to develop it creatively. You improve upon their vision; we put the pixie dust on it. One thing I’ve learned is, don’t completely eliminate or poop all over someone else’s stuff.

As part of Research Question 2, participants were asked what they would do if a colleague's work was so sloppy that it created additional work for them. Alexis discussed using tact with a colleague and going over a mistake without accusation, using kindness in her approach. She stated:

First, I would actually talk to the person and just ask them, "Hey, you know, is there anything that you need assistance on?" Or I would bring up like a document and say, you know, "Have you seen this document before? You know, maybe we can go over it together," without accusing someone of something, because they might not know, and they might not realize that that is what's happening. So, I would just approach the person in a kind, tactful way.

After Soleia kept receiving incorrect and late items, she and her colleague came up with a process to reduce the potential for incorrect information to be submitted. She reported:

Instead of saying, "The way you do it sucks," we're like, "We're trying a new way to get this information from you," basically without making anybody feel bad. I think that's a good way to resolve any type of issues that we may have.

Not all participants were willing to work around colleagues. Other participants said if they saw a problem with a co-worker, they would speak to their manager about the situation.

The findings in Research Question 2 make clear that being self-starting and proactive were also two of the ways employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace.

Participants were proactive when issues arose and worked to solve them *before* they became problems. Interpersonal competence was an emerging theme for Research Question 2.

Participants used kindness, tact, and interpersonal savvy in their approaches with colleagues. By

being proactive in resolving or avoiding problems in interpersonal relationships, they demonstrated their commitment to the team.

Findings for Research Question 3

Research Question 3 was, “How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?” The findings for Research Question 3 indicated that participants perceived personal initiative impacting their career achievement in various ways. Themes that emerged from Research Question 3 included promotion, recognition, opportunity for growth, recognition, and team commitment. Examples of how participants perceived the impact of personal initiative on their career achievement are outlined in Table 4.

Table 4

Research Question 3: Participant Perceptions of the Impact of Personal Initiative on Their Career Achievement

Theme	Example Quote
Promotion	“I’ve had four promotions since I started working here in 2013 . . . Each promotion is certainly something that I very much impressed myself that I have attained. So yeah, first of all initiative, just researching new techniques and emerging technologies that has played no small role in finding myself where I am today.” (Daughtrey)
Growth Opportunity	“To begin with, I worked in the food and beverage industry . . . at a later time in my life, [I] went back to school and got my degree and started a new career . . . I probably knew a good year ahead of time that the company was leaving the Atlanta area . . . I started researching what was available to me. I had been thinking about it for a while before that, but that kind of just pushed me a little bit more. I found out that because of my age and gender, I was eligible for some federal retraining dollars.” (Katie)

Table 4 (continued)*Research Question 3: Participant Perceptions of the Impact of Personal Initiative on Their Career Achievement*

Theme	Example Quote
Recognition	“I got more noticed and respected I think among my managers and those who would make the hiring decisions later by displaying more initiative than some of the other . . . workers, especially as far as addressing issues that were still outstanding. In the latter case, it would be again initiative because if I hadn’t taken the trouble to try to learn more about it, I probably would still be floundering around.” (Apollo)
Recognition	“I received an award . . . and it’s a really nice award . . . it was very humbling . . . it was emotional to be recognized in that way. I was very thankful . . . Because you come to work, you do your job . . . you don’t think people notice . . . but to hear the kind words that your peers say, and what they think of you . . . that was very kind. It was very, very humbling.” (Alexis)
Recognition/Promotion	“I got recognized for my self-initiative work, at an early time span. I got recognized in six months that I had taken the time to go in and complete this entire certification . . . I became part-time . . . then a full-time employee.” (Joseph)
Recognition	“Winning [an employee award] would have to rank up there pretty high. I kept saying, what did I do to deserve this? The previous winner was somebody I really looked up to, she really went the extra mile for the students she worked with. The people who were nominated the year I won, it was all people I really respected and admired.” (Wen)
Team Commitment	“Unboxing cash registers is not necessarily part of my job description, but there was a need and I said I was willing to assist with setting up the new ones and unboxing them, making sure like, hey, this one doesn’t work, so testing all of the registers to make sure all the keys work for all the drawers, making sure we had two sets of keys for all of them, making sure there was no damage to the actual equipment.” (Soleia)

Career Achievement Beyond Individual Gain

Another finding from the participants' responses regarding the impact of personal initiative on career achievement was the importance of being recognized by their peers. Participants also talked about achievement as encompassing more than just a salary increase. Daughtrey discussed how the sense of accomplishment that results from a salary increase does not last, stating:

That sense of accomplishment from that salary increase is remarkably fleeting. I would actually place more value in the respect that I get from my colleagues. You know, when vice presidents are asking me questions directly, I'm extremely flattered by that. Just the recognition.

In defining career achievement, Wen identified reputation as more important than money, reflecting:

Well, it's not always, you know, especially in my case, is not always getting big promotions and ending up making, you know, more and more and more money. To me, it's more about reputation, you know, can people count on you? Can you perform enough to where you can actually keep your job? Not only keep it, but you know, make your boss look good, make your department look good.

Soleia noted that her happiness was ultimately what would aid in her personal growth. Money was not her goal; she wanted to have enough money but still be happy in her job. She explained:

I'm not big on the, oh, let's go try to find a new job every year or so to see if I can get more money, be more competitive, see what's out there. That's really not my way of personal initiative.

Similarly, Joseph did not necessarily see recognition or awards as career achievement. He stated:

I don't see career achievements as awards, or I'll go as far as even to say recognition. I don't see that as being achievement. I see it as someone *acknowledging* [emphasis added] your achievements, but I don't see those as being achievements. It is more of when you think about that person, what do you think of? Do you think, oh yeah, I remember when they were here. It was an easy day. It was smooth; things weren't chaotic. I had as much help as I needed. If I had an issue, I could go to that person and it will get resolved.

Based on the findings from Research Question 3, it can be understood that employees perceived personal initiative as impacting their careers through promotions, growth opportunities, recognition, and team commitment. Recognition and team commitment were part of the finding that while participants appreciated things that impacted individual career gain, it was vital for them to be recognized by their peers.

Interconnected Themes

The themes that were interconnected throughout all three research questions included taking initiative, being proactive, being self-directed as a learner, and being committed to the team. Being proactive is a part of personal initiative and involves acting in advance (Frese, 2006). In the workplace, proactive employees display innovative work behavior, and proactive *teams* seek continuous improvement, modify work processes, and pursue innovative solutions to work problems (Hyatt & Ruddy, 1997).

Though Soleia's job was to make sure cash registers had the correct operating software, she assisted colleagues by unboxing the registers. Soleia shared that she could not allow herself

to be the kind of person who says, “Oh yeah, let me know when my aspect of the job shows up.”

Teams that are highly committed are emotionally invested in the success of the team as a whole, and their actions are motivated by the team’s best interests. This commitment permits a greater level of self-direction, goal-motivation, and citizenship (Li et al., 2018). Self-direction, the pursuit of goals, and citizenship are all interrelated with personal initiative.

Self-directed learning encourages individuals to develop models to approach and solve problems (Guglielmino & Murdick, 1997). In responding to the question of how personal initiative impacted his career achievement, Apollo discussed the desire to understand what he was doing by testing and looking up things he did not know. He stated:

In theory, maybe the minimum I could do to be able to set up a system is make, like, a diagram of what wires exactly would connect to what ports and how they would be arranged, and then that would be it. Instead, I’ve tried to understand why it all works that way and get more overall knowledge that I can apply to other pieces of equipment.

When participants learned something on their own, they also shared that knowledge with others. Gerber et al. (1995) emphasized that workers saw interpersonal observation as a valuable way to learn most efficiently in the workplace.

Summary

This chapter presented an overview of the participants’ perceptions and narratives and interconnected themes that emerged from participant interviews. The narratives were guided by responses from the interview questions, along with additional feedback from the participants. Chapter 5 will provide a comprehensive summary of the study. The chapter will also present an interpretation of the findings, the study’s conclusions, implications for practice, and recommendations for future research.

CHAPTER 5

INTERPRETATION OF FINDINGS, CONCLUSIONS, IMPLICATIONS, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The preceding chapter presented the study's findings, along with common and emergent themes. Chapter 5 includes a summary of the study, an interpretation of the findings, a discussion of the conclusions, implications for practice, and future research recommendations. This research aimed to explore how employees perceive the concept of personal initiative and its impact on career achievement. The following questions guided the research:

1. How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?
2. How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?
3. How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

A basic qualitative approach was used to understand participants' perceptions of personal initiative and its impact on their career achievement. Eight participants were interviewed for the study. The sample was purposefully selected with criterion sampling as the specific strategy.

The data were collected through semi-structured interviews using an interview guide. All interviews were done remotely through the Zoom application. Seven interviews were face-to-face; one interview was by phone. Interviews were recorded and transcribed using Otter.ai, which turns audio into smart notes. The smart notes were then converted to a Microsoft Word document, which I coded using initial (open) and in vivo coding methods.

Interpretation of Findings

Research Question 1: How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?

According to Frese et al. (1996), displays of personal initiative are self-starting and proactive. Consistent with the literature, participants perceived personal initiative as being self-starting and proactive. Participants in this study perceived personal initiative as doing things themselves and not waiting to be told or having things assigned to do them. Crant (2000) defined employees' proactive behavior as "taking initiative in improving current circumstances or creating new ones; it involves challenging the status quo rather than passively adapting to present conditions" (p. 436).

The findings from Research Question 1 also suggest that participants were self-starting in their desire to learn. Participants in this study took the initiative to stay current and took steps to learn on their own if training was not available. In the process of self-directed learning, the learner takes the initiative to identify their learning needs and goals, choose learning resources and strategies, and evaluate learning outcomes (Knowles, 1975). Nimble operations and the flattening of organizations have called for employees to be more independent and self-directed. This creates an environment where learning occurs without strong oversight of the organization and is increasingly the responsibility of employees and teams (Lemmetty & Collin, 2020).

Smith (2002) emphasized that there is value in organizations supporting employees' efforts to become self-directed learners, so they cultivate and pursue their learning goals and outcomes without direct instruction. Amina shared, "My motto is if I don't know how to do it yet, I'll know how to do it by this evening. That's how I've survived truly in my field; I've had to do that quickly." In some cases, after they found solutions for themselves, participants shared

the information with others. In the long run, a commitment to self-learning and development benefits both the learners and their employers (Long & Morris, 1995).

Another finding from Research Question 1 was that participants consistently emphasized the importance of helping and being counted on by others. Singh and Gupta (2015) noted that “team commitment is the psychological attachment that members feel toward the team” (p. 1196). More than one participant discussed the importance of going above and beyond in their role to make the work more manageable for a team member. Kevin shared, “Sometimes it means going the extra mile . . . if you’re not there for the team, the work doesn’t get done as efficiently.”

I found the emergence of team commitment as a theme surprising because team commitment was not part of the literature on personal initiative or proactivity. However, Foote and Tang (2008) proposed a relationship between team commitment and organizational citizenship behavior, which is closely related (but not identical) to personal initiative. For these participants, experiencing personal initiative means going above and beyond in their roles and for other team members.

Individuals Who Display Personal Initiative Understand It Has Disadvantages

Though participants perceived personal initiative as being self-starting, proactive, self-directed as learners, and committed to the team, they also recognized that displaying personal initiative has disadvantages. Participants noted the risks of potential burnout, becoming overwhelmed, and people sometimes jumping in when they did not have the experience to handle a work process. The burnout process begins when energy turns into exhaustion (Maslach & Leiter, 1997). Apollo talked about the potential for getting burned out. “If you are not careful

and you just try to pick up anything that pops up and work on it, then you can get yourself burned out on being able to work as effectively at anything.”

Displaying personal initiative and going above and beyond can also create additional stress for an employee. Podsakoff et al. (2000) defined *individual initiative* as a specific type of organizational citizenship behavior in which employees “engage in task-related behaviors at a level that is so far beyond minimally required or generally expected levels that it takes on a voluntary flavor” (p. 524). Organ (1988) observed that initiative and organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) go beyond individual role requirements. A stressful work environment can drain employees’ energy levels, leaving limited resources available to dedicate to OCB (Bolino & Turnley, 2005).

Research Question 2: How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?

Proactive people identify opportunities, act on them, show initiative, and persevere until they bring about meaningful change (Bateman & Crant, 1993). Several participants noted seeing a need and attempting to find a solution to a problem. Problem-solving or finding solutions is another top essential skill that employers seek. Frensch and Funke (1995) noted that operations caused by a problem go beyond everyday action and thinking. Employers want employees who use higher-level thinking methods to solve problems (Carnevale & Smith, 2013). In a systematic literature review, Osmani et al. (2019) found that problem-solving was one of the top four core interpersonal skills for graduate employability.

Amina discussed seeing a need for a more interactive guide and teaching herself new software to develop the guide. She stated:

I see a need. We have a guide right now that could benefit from being more interactive.

I'm building a sample right now. There's a software I'm using I've never used before, so

I'm teaching myself how to use it right now.

Participants used interpersonal competence to collaborate with teammates with different work personalities. The broad definition of interpersonal competence is the ability to interact with others (Giromini et al., 2016). Buhrmester et al. (1988) identified five domains of interpersonal competence: (1) initiation of interactions and relationships, (2) assertion of personal rights and displeasure with others, (3) self-disclosure of personal information, (4) emotional support of others, and (5) management of interpersonal conflicts that arise in close relationships.

When asked about colleagues doing sloppy work, several participants sought respectful solutions to keep work flowing. Amina shared that she observed and listened and pulled back, depending on the situation, stating:

I have learned to observe and listen. It's very important to pay attention to people's personalities. That's how I kind of navigate. I have learned how to pull back or push forward depending on the group of people or the individual I am working with. So, it's kind of a little bit of skill and not therapy or psychology, but just a touch of that to understand the dynamic of who you're working with or who you're working for.

McConnell (2018) asserted that to improve interpersonal competence, individuals must consistently observe others, interpret their actions, and adjust their behavior to suit the goals of those interactions. Interpersonal competence requires higher-level skills, in that an individual does not want to adjust so much that they lose themselves. Interpersonal competence is also a skill that might potentially be very important post-COVID-19. Understandably, there is little

research as to how this type of isolation impacts children and adults. Miller (2020) suggests that the interpersonal skills of adults may rebound, but they may decline in children.

Research Question 3: How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

I was surprised by the participants' responses to the question of how personal initiative has impacted their career achievement. I expected to hear mostly about *personal* gain. DuBrin (2013) observed that a proactive person might receive more career rewards, such as a higher salary, more promotions, and greater prestige. Seibert et al. (1999) also connected proactivity to more beneficial salary, promotion, and career outcomes. In answering questions about their most significant career achievements, participants revealed that they did have growth opportunities and promotions. However, participants also highlighted the importance of recognition from fellow team members. Employees appreciate receiving recognition from the team members with whom they work every day. Unexpected recognition from a team member can have a particularly compelling impact (Vranjes, 2014). Being commended for their work performance sheds light on the work process, creativity, innovation, and continuous improvement employees bring to their work approach (Brun & Dugas, 2008).

Though Daughtrey reported receiving multiple promotions, he also noted that the feeling of accomplishment from a salary increase was temporary, stating:

I would actually place more value in the respect that I get from my colleagues. And just, the recognition. You know we have these award ceremonies. Every once in a while, I'm a nominee for something like that. That's extra flattering.

Most organizations acknowledge that it takes more than a high salary to motivate and encourage employees. The initial positive impact of a bonus or pay raise are lost somewhat

quickly (Whitaker, 2010). Moreover, given the economy's current state, rewarding employees with promotions or raises may not be possible in some sectors. Jyothi (2016) emphasized that “the need for recognition, self-respect, growth, meaningful work, [*sic*] social activities are as important as monetary incentives in increasing the employees’ morale and motivation” (p. 45).

Joseph discussed the importance of serving as a mentor for those who come after him. He stated:

So that’s where my achievement is, right there. I did something right; I took the time to train, to nurture, and to teach everything that I knew to make them that much more of a better analyst and worker, and they’ve taken that and surpassed it. So now I can look at him and be like, that person themselves is my career achievement. As long as they surpass where I’m at, then I did my job. I uplifted the guy that was coming after me to go on and be great and do great things.

While personal initiative impacted participants’ careers through promotions, salary increases, and growth opportunities, being recognized by their team members and nurturing others was also of great significance.

Conclusions

This study contributes to the literature on personal initiative and proactive behavior. Most of the studies done on personal initiative have been quantitative (Frese et al., 1996; Frese & Fay, 2001; Frese et al., 2007; Lisbona et al., 2018). As this is a basic qualitative study that illuminates employees’ perceptions of personal initiative, it adds a different element to the body of research.

The findings from the analysis of the data collected through participant interviews led to the following conclusions:

1. Employees who display personal initiative perceive and experience it as being self-starting and proactive and use a not-waiting-to-be-told approach when it comes to learning on their own.
2. Employees who display personal initiative understand that there are disadvantages to going above and beyond in their roles.
3. Employees experience personal initiative in the workplace as taking the initiative to find solutions to issues *before* they become problems.
4. Employees who display personal initiative also display interpersonal competence and a commitment to other team members.
5. Personal initiative impacts employee career achievement through promotions, salary increases, and growth opportunities; however, employees also perceive being recognized by team members as a significant part of their career achievement.

Emerging technologies and global competition call for individuals to be autonomous and self-directed as learners. Individuals in this study did not wait to be told what to do. Not only did they perceive personal initiative as self-starting and proactive they were also self-directed as learners. The responsibility to learn often lies with the individual or the team (Lemmetty & Collin, 2020). As organizations face the financial implications of COVID-19, they may have limited if any funding available to provide formal training. Having employees who will take it upon themselves to learn on their own is beneficial not only for the organization but also for the growth of the employee.

Along with being self-directed learners, participants were also problem-solvers. The problems that arise in the knowledge-based 21st century are often disruptive and unstructured, requiring innovative problem-solving skills (Kim et al., 2018). “Not waiting to be told” was an

element of multiple participant responses. Proactive individuals anticipate and visualize future outcomes and adapt to situations to create those outcomes (Aspinwall & Taylor, 1997).

Hartog and Belschak (2007) suggested that employees who display a high level of initiative are viewed by managers making appraisal decisions as hardworking contributors who take on more responsibility. It is not surprising that employees who display personal initiative receive promotions and professional growth opportunities. However, despite these positive outcomes of personal initiative, employees also understand that displaying personal initiative has some drawbacks and that sometimes being proactive can lead to negative outcomes.

Taking initiative is not always a good thing. Seibert et al. (2001) found that workers who challenge present conditions *without* offering innovative solutions to problems could negatively impact their careers. Moreover, while many individuals with high levels of personal initiative experience a sense of well-being (DuBrin, 2013), personal initiative can also lead to work overwhelm and job stress (Bolino & Turnley, 2005). If supervisors and team members are pleased with the proactive behavior, they will be more likely to reward it; if they are dissatisfied with the proactive behavior, they will be more likely to punish it (Grant & Ashford, 2008). Frese and Fay (2001) pointed out that personal initiative, a form of proactive behavior, is not always welcomed by supervisors. Initiative can rock the boat, and it can also spark change. Since people tend not to like change, they may greet initiative with skepticism (Begley, 1998).

A self-starting, proactive, and competent individual might *not* take action if they surveyed their environment and saw that *not* taking action was the best approach. Thus, taking initiative might involve being proactively passive if that was judged to be the best behavior in a particular set of circumstances.

Neininger et al. (2010) measured extra-role behavior towards co-workers using the OCB altruism scale and found that team commitment leads to higher performance and altruism. The team commitment and interpersonal competence of participants in this study are likely related to their appreciation of recognition from their peers. When employees are appreciated by their peers, they feel they belong to a community (Brun & Dugas, 2008).

Helping others was a consistent theme across the interview responses. Wen discussed the importance of “coming through” for his colleagues. When working with one client in particular, Joseph shared that he could tell she was becoming frustrated. Joseph described how he visualized her as a family member and calmed her while assisting with her technology issue.

In one of Alexis’ responses about how she experienced personal initiative in the workplace, she discussed staying late to support a team member, stating:

There was someone who was needing assistance, and they were going to be here pretty late. I stayed; I didn’t have to. I was not asked to, but it ended up being helpful to the other person because they weren’t just here by themselves. I could feel that it was needed.

Though Amina was fearful of retribution, she took the initiative to speak out about pay equity in her former role. She expressed:

That was scary for me because I was afraid of, you know, retribution. I felt like at the time it was so grossly disparaging that I had to say something, put it on record, and I didn’t know if it was going to necessarily change anything. A lot of times with these situations you have to make it better for the next me, for the next you who comes in the door.

For Amina, it was important to say something to improve the situation for those who came after her, even if it meant potential retaliation. As going above and beyond (extra-role behavior) is an attribute of both personal initiative and organizational citizenship behavior, it makes sense that going above and beyond for team members was also a part of Amina's work experience.

Implications for Practice

In 2020, the workforce has had to adapt in multiple ways, with remote work becoming a reality for many. Going forward, employers will continue to make decisions concerning employee productivity and remote work (Brynjolfsson et al., 2020). In a time of turbulence, many organizations are focused on hiring and retaining proactive employees who are self-motivated, ready to contribute, and forward-thinking (Rahman et al., 2017).

This study informs those individuals who are in a position to hire employees. The questions developed from this study can be modified and used as part of the hiring process or used in a team evaluation process. For example, instead of asking someone if they prefer working individually or in a team, someone might ask, "tell me about a time when you went above and beyond to assist a team member without being asked?" As McCormick et al. (2019) suggested, "from a selection perspective, one option organizations have is to seek employees who are inherently predisposed to behave proactively" (p. 31). This study's findings outline many of the attributes organizations seek when hiring employees and can inform the work of career development facilitators, employees and employers, human resource development professionals, students, and workforce development professionals.

Career development facilitators work in various settings to assist students, clients, and employees with career information and skill development (Kerbrat & Kluesner, 2018). The findings of this study can provide valuable guidance for career development facilitators who

work in K-12 and in higher education. Higher education institutions are collaborating with industry to help students bridge the gap between their education and their first jobs (Cruzvergara et al., 2018). Programming that highlights being self-starting and proactive is necessary for prospective employees and instills key characteristics necessary for taking control of one's career.

Employees have the expanded responsibility of managing their careers, and the notion of a career path has become increasingly ambiguous (Sheldon & Wallace, 2014). Colleges and universities must consider how students can attain specific and career-ready learning outcomes by graduation (Fox, 2018). Career center programming that incorporates the findings from this study into modules or other learning outcomes could prove beneficial to students.

At the K-12 level, introducing personal initiative scenarios to students will mean crafting scenarios that create awareness. For example, at each level (elementary, middle, and high school), you might use a game and leave out a piece of the game. How do students adapt? Did they see a piece was missing and not move forward? Did they create a piece and continue through the process? Did they use problem-solving skills? Cognitive problem-solving skills training has been detailed in the literature (Kazdin & Weisz, 1998). After an exercise, the instructor can ask questions, encourage students to generate alternatives, and debrief them, which creates awareness. Adolescents are active, and their life experiences suggest they learn by doing (Danish et al., 2004). Scenarios and skills training will not necessarily “teach” personal initiative, but it gives students insight and awareness of this essential skill. McKeough et al. (2013) noted that “a key finding among educational researchers is that in order for the transfer of learning to transpire successfully, a student must be (a) prepared with knowledge and strategies of the

learned content, (b) able to access those resources readily, and (c) motivated to implement the life skill in another setting.

Rojewski and Hill (2017) noted that Career and Technical Education (CTE) programming already stresses dependability, initiative, and interpersonal skills, but greater emphasis and purpose is needed. Initiative is a part of work ethic training. Rojewski and Hill (2014) noted that “one of the challenges for CTE educators when addressing work ethic instruction is having appropriate curriculum materials to guide instruction” (p. 146). Findings from this study can be weaved into the CTE curriculum. For example, in the Foundations of Engineering Course at Martin Luther King High School, students are given real-world business problems through 3DE training. With 3DE, high school education is re-engineered to be more relevant, experiential, and connecting to the complexities of the real world. Case methodology is used to increase student engagement, strengthen comprehension, build critical thinking, and accelerate academic performance (3DE, n.d). Though this is an engineering course, the instructor introduces interpersonal skill scenarios to compliment the 3DE training (Tracy Marshall, personal communication, November 22, 2020). Findings from this study offer real world examples of personal initiative and can be modified to compliment courses like this in a CTE curriculum. Soleia’s example of unboxing the cash registers though it was not part of her job could be lengthened into a case study. It could be framed as: If you showed up to load software on a set of computers but realized the task could not be completed because other staff had not yet unboxed the computers, what next steps would you take? In CTE (and work related and academic training) problem-solving strategies and coping behavior are just as important as technical skills (Rojewski & Hill, 2017). For students to be prepared for the 21st century workforce they must be introduced to these types of examples.

Using a systematic methodology focused on long-term goals, human resource development (HRD) professionals build capacity in individuals, teams, and organizations (Bierema & Eraut, 2004).

Swanson and Holton (2009) defined HRD as:

The process of developing and unleashing expertise for the purpose of improving individual, team, work process, and organizational system performance. HRD efforts typically take place under the additional banners of “training and development” and “organization development” as well as numerous other titles. (p. 4)

In an organization, HRD professionals are often responsible for creating and facilitating leadership and training development plans for the entire organization. Proactive strategies are prominent in a workforce environment that is broadly based, and learning is increasingly acknowledged as a principal solution to human talent challenges (Bergman et al., 2018). The findings from this study can be incorporated into the learning plans HRD professionals develop.

Working in various settings, workforce development professionals serve job seekers by providing academic and skills training and career assistance to help them identify and secure employment. They also serve local employers by matching skilled applicants to employers’ needs (Certified Workforce Development Professional, 2018). To remain competitive and keep their heads above water in a globalized economy, organizations have been forced to continually evaluate the benefits of workforce development projects (Short & Harris, 2014).

Through workforce development programs, individuals can gain relevant experience, obtain work-related credentials, and improve technical and soft skills. (Eyster et al., 2013). The participants’ perceptions and experiences in this study can be used to integrate problem-based

learning approaches into workforce development programming. Problem-based learning guides students to solve problems and reflect on their experiences (Barrows & Tamblyn, 1980).

Adults learn by being involved and they bring their experiences to the learning process (Knowles, 1980). Cognition in adults is connected to life experience and is applicable to students of varying ages who come from various socio-economic and cultural backgrounds (Goddu, 2012). Experiential learning provides a setting for the way knowledge will be used in real life (Herrington & Oliver, 1995). As essential skills training plays a vital role in developing the workforce, the findings of this study offer a valuable contribution for workforce development professionals seeking material to help clients enhance their cognitive skills.

Recommendations for Future Research

Connecting Self-Efficacy with Personal Initiative

Personal initiative is a work theory (Frese, 1996). Personal initiative can be defined as the predisposition to execute self-initiated actions that are future-oriented. The objective of these actions is to improve or change aspects of the environment or oneself (Frese & Fay, 2001). There is limited research about the role personal initiative plays in personal development. As personal initiative is a work theory, it is understandable that the research is limited to how it develops earlier in individuals' development before their first work experience.

Frese (1996) noted that self-efficacy is closely related to personal initiative. Bandura (1997) defined self-efficacy as "beliefs in one's capabilities to organize and execute the courses of action required to produce given attainments" (p. 3). Students with a strong sense of self-efficacy for achieving an educational task will participate more actively, work harder, and persist longer when facing challenges than those who question their capabilities (Zimmerman, 1995).

Studying the relationship between personal initiative and self-efficacy could help illuminate how personal initiative develops in individuals. Recent research has connected personal initiative and self-efficacy (Solesvik, 2017; Lisbona et al., 2018; Putra et al., 2020). However, these recent studies focus only on adults. Future studies could investigate the association between self-efficacy and personal initiative by modifying the SDT and PI scales for children and adolescents.

Personal Initiative and First-Generation College Students

Half of the participants in this study were first-generation college students. Though the definition can vary, the National Center for Education Statistics (1998) defined first-generation college students as “students whose parents have no postsecondary education. In some cases . . . ‘first-generation’ students are defined as students whose parents have never earned a bachelor’s degree but may have some postsecondary experience” (p. 1).

There has been limited research about the career development of first-generation college students (Tate et al., 2015). The first-generation participants interviewed for this study indicated a sense of knowing they needed to demonstrate initiative in the workplace. They would say things like, “I just knew,” which is something I also felt in my journey as a first-generation college student.

How is it that first-generation students “just know” when it comes to taking initiative? Does their first-generation status contribute to feeling compelled to push harder at work and to go above and beyond? Tate et al. (2015) noted that the first-generation college participants in their study had a similar way of describing their identities. Participants discussed persistence and motivation, appreciativeness and low entitlement, self-reliance and responsibility, and adaptability. Much has been written about the obstacles and challenges that first-generation

college students face (Stephens et al., 2014; Pitre & Pitre, 2009; Unverferth et al., 2012). A research study on personal initiative in first-generation college students could provide insights beyond challenges and barriers that could help academic institutions recruit and retain them.

Personal Initiative and Black Employees

One of the Black participants interviewed for this study recalled how her mother told her she would need to work twice as hard as others and that she had to be the best and could not be mediocre. Her mother's exact words were, "You gotta be twice as good, work twice as hard no matter what you do. If you are lucky, you might get equal, probably not."

A version of this saying was shared with me by my parents. DeSante (2013) found that Blacks and Whites are not rewarded equally when sticking to the traditional American norm of hard work. The Great Recession also demonstrated that working hard and playing by the rules did not necessarily translate to success (Hamilton et al., 2015). A significant number of biased employment decisions are not motivated by discriminatory actions as outlined by the Civil Rights era's legal frameworks but result from a variety of inadvertent judgment oversights associated with normal human cognitive functioning (Krieger, 1995). These oversights are still evident in the wake of the social justice and equity efforts of 2020. Future research to discover whether and to what extent Black people believe that they must work twice as hard, go above and beyond, and go out of their way to volunteer in organizations for reasons other than personal initiative could prove timely.

Limitations

Selecting a sample size in qualitative research is a topic of much debate among researchers (Vasileou et al., 2018). The purposeful sampling method used in this study yielded eight participants. Given the complexity of case-oriented analysis, samples in qualitative studies

tend to be smaller in size, which is essential to this investigation method (Sandelowski, 1995). The size of the sample was a limitation in this study. However, when formulating a justification for sample size in qualitative research, reference must be made to the scope of the study and the nature of the topic (Morse, 2000).

The purpose of this study was to explore employee perceptions of personal initiative and its impact on their career achievement. Polit and Beck (2010) observed that “the goal of most qualitative studies is not to generalize but rather to provide a rich, contextualized understanding of some aspect of human experience through the intensive study of particular cases” (p. 1451). The aim of this research is not to suggest that the findings of this study can be generalized to other organizations. However, the findings of this study can *inform* organizations and be applied to other sites.

The small sample size had an impact on the descriptive information provided for the participants. According to Tolich (2004), *deductive disclosure*, also known as internal confidentiality, can occur when participants’ traits can be identified in research reports. The participants’ home department is small (31), and the findings of this study reveal that these members collaborate and have positive interpersonal relationships. As teammates, they might identify each other based on demographic descriptors and other information provided in the interviews.

Qualitative research often contains participants’ personal experiences; thus, qualitative researchers are exceptionally concerned about harming respondents (Baez, 2002). To protect the identities of the participants, they were assigned pseudonyms. Even with pseudonyms, however, the contextual identifiers in the participants’ life stories remain. Therefore, consideration must be

given to whether specific quotes and examples may lead to participants being identified by deductive disclosure (Kaiser, 2009).

I did not ask participants their age because I felt it would make them identifiable to the department head or fellow colleagues and jeopardize their anonymity. Additionally, there were responses provided by the participants that would have complemented and reinforced specific themes. I did not include these responses in this study. However, those answers might have provided a deductive way to determine the identity of the participant. A larger sample size might allow for more rich and descriptive information to be shared.

When discussing the age at which they first experienced personal initiative, several participants discussed familial influences. Parental and other family influences have a role in work ethic and development in children. Children's development of work values and feelings about work begin early in life and are influenced by parents (Leenders et al., 2017). Vocational psychologists have become increasingly conscious of the impact an individual's family of origin has on their career development (Fouad et al., 2010). Turner and Lapan (2002) identified parental support as a crucial predictor of the career self-efficacy of adolescents in the general population.

I was hesitant to probe and ask participants to reflect on familial influences more deeply because personal initiative is a work theory. As a novice researcher, I was fearful of not straying from the questions about work and career achievement. I was also hesitant to add information provided about family to the vignettes, as I was worried that other participants would be familiar with their colleagues' life stories. More probing on this question could have provided greater insight as to the source of the participant's development of personal initiative.

Personal Journey

It is hard to put the value of my dissertation experience into words. Dr. Rojewski told us early on in our journey that in this process, “you are the student and the teacher.” Throughout this journey, I heard those words repeatedly in my head. There is much that you must teach yourself in the doctoral process, especially after coursework is complete. Being a witness to my work evolving and my writing improving filled me with a sense of pride.

Recently, the Mary Frances Early College of Education's social media account sent out a call asking students to share our COVID-19 stories of resilience. There were many roadblocks placed in front of me during this journey. Through these last few years, my dissertation served as a positive beacon of light. One hour after I found out I had lost my job due to a layoff; I had a meeting with Dr. Janette Hill via Zoom. I thought, “no time to worry, I have a paper to write.”

My paper then went from being my lighthouse to being my lifeline. I shared in my COVID-19 resilience story that “keep moving forward” is my personal mantra. It makes sense that to complete this goal and finish my dissertation, I needed to persist and overcome barriers. Finishing is a triumphant feeling.

Final Thoughts

Over four decades ago, Hall (1976) wrote of the emergence of a “protean career” in which individual actors, not organizations, drove their careers based more upon their own psychological success and decisions than upon a structure, sequence, or set of standards imposed by the organization. Having self-understanding offers insight into the vital career management skills an employee needs to develop. Employees who can use their strengths *and* weaknesses to manage their careers can develop more significant and detailed plans (Raabe et al., 2007). Protean attitudes have been defined as involving self-directed career management and a “values-

driven” career orientation, with an emphasis on individuals’ values (versus, for example, organizational values) driving their careers (Briscoe et al., 2006). A protean career is in alignment with personal initiative.

Proactive employees who succeed within these dynamic environments do so by realizing that they do not have to play the hand dealt to them. Instead, top performers tend to proactively create circumstances that facilitate personal and organizational success as they strive to reach their goals (Ashford & Black, 1996; Chan & Schmitt, 2000). Rojewski and Hill (2017) argued that “workers who can understand and navigate a dynamic workplace using career-related information about self and the world of work are likely to enjoy successful careers in the 21st century workplace” (p. 187). Similarly, career researchers argue that individuals will rely less on their organizations in contemporary careers and instead take initiative themselves in their personal and career development (Hall & Chandler, 2005).

In today’s global marketplace, employers consider soft skills critical for success (Stewart et al., 2016). Initiative, problem solving, staying current, and teamwork are some of the top skills employers seek (NACE, 2015; Hart Research Associates, 2015). Eighty-eight percent of the participants in this study were rated as having high PI or moderate PI. In addition to perceiving personal initiative as being self-starting and proactive, participants took the approach of not waiting to be told to solve problems and of learning independently. The participants also displayed interpersonal competence and had a strong commitment to the team.

The participants in this study are the kinds of employees organizations want to hire and the kinds of colleagues people want to work with inside an organization. The perceptions and experiences highlighted in this study may lead to creating scenarios and case studies that can be incorporated earlier into career readiness training. This training will help youth, students, and

adults be better prepared for a disrupted workforce that has seen drastic changes and continues to evolve rapidly.

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APPENDIX A

GENERAL STAFF PERFORMANCE APPRAISAL FORM

Employee Name (Last, First, MI):	Performance Review Date:	
Job Title:	Position Number	BCAT Code:
Business Title:	Department:	

	DUTIES AND RESPONSIBILITIES	% Time	Comments (Mandatory)
#1			
#2			
#3			
#4			
#5			
#6			
#7			

B. General Performance Dimensions	Supervisor's Evaluation Comments (Mandatory)
1 Leadership (motivation, direction, task/goal orientation, etc).	
2 Job Knowledge (technical, non-technical, policies, etc).	
3 Personal/Professional Development	
4 Communications (written, oral, non-verbal, etc).	
5 Human Relations (listening, encouragement, tact, ability to get along with others etc).	

6 Resource Utilization (budgeting, management, etc).	
7 Planning (mission-orientation, strategic, etc).	
8 Teamwork (consensus, equity, cohesiveness, etc).	
9 Institutional Commitment (supports university objectives; good public relations, etc.)	

C. Individual Responsibility	Supervisor's Evaluation Comments (Mandatory)
1 Observance of work hours	
2 Safety practices	
3 Quality of work	
4 Initiative	
5 Customer Service	

Prior Goals/Objectives Achieved:				
Goals/Objectives for Next Evaluation Period:				
1.				
2.				
3.				
4.				
Employee Signature: _____ This report has been discussed with me. I understand my signature does not necessarily indicate agreement. (Attach additional sheets if necessary to record comments). Employees comments (if any): _____ _____ _____ Evaluator's Signature: _____ Reviewer's Signature: _____			Overall Rating ☐ Outstanding ☐ Excellent ☐ Standard ☐ Low Standard ☐ Needs Improvement The overall rating is a cumulative rating based on the various components of the evaluation form, which may be weighted differently.	

NEEDS IMPROVEMENT	LOW STANDARD	STANDARD	EXCELLENT	OUTSTANDING
Does not meet expectations	Meets most expectations	Meets all expectations	Frequently exceeds most expectations	Consistently exceeds all expectations

APPENDIX B

MANAGER'S INVITATION LETTER

Dear Prospective Research Participant:

My name is Lisa D. Conley, and I am a doctoral student in the Workforce Education Department at the University of Georgia. I am conducting a study entitled *Exploring Employee Perceptions of Personal Initiative and its Impact Career Achievement*. The primary purpose of this research is to explore how university employees perceive the concept of personal initiative as it relates to career achievement.

The project involves two tasks. First, you will read the definition of personal initiative (PI). *Personal initiative* refers to the actions an individual exhibits at work that are characterized by a self-starting nature, a proactive approach, and a persistence in overcoming problems occur in the pursuit of a goal.

Then you will select employees based on the attributes that define PI. Please select a mix of individuals: those who highly demonstrate personal initiative, those who do not exhibit the behavior at all, and some who fall in the middle. Participation is expected to take approximately 30 minutes.

If you have any questions about your participation in this research, please ask them before you begin.

If you have any questions or concerns about the nature of this study, please contact Lisa Conley, Department of Career and Information Studies (Workforce Education), University of Georgia, Athens, GA 30602, 404-432-0766.

Thank you for assisting with this research.

Respectfully,

Lisa Conley, M.Ed.
Workforce Education Doctoral Student
University of Georgia

APPENDIX C

DEPARTMENT HEAD EMAIL TO EMPLOYEES

April 7, 2020

Colleagues,

First of all, I would like to thank each of you for your continued great work during the current crisis. I hear all of the time that...employees have been critical in the move to fully on-line and that our service has continued as if nothing has changed. For that I am grateful and again, thank you very much!

A short time ago I was contacted by...now working on her doctorate at The University of Georgia, who has asked to interview some of us as part of her research. Her name is Lisa Conley, and her email is lconley3@uga.edu. I have provided her a list of our employees and email addresses. She may be reaching out to some of you in the near future.

I want to emphasize that **this is strictly voluntary** and that she will NOT be contacting everyone. If you are contacted, please consider helping Lisa with her research. I will in no way monitor who she interviews and/or what is said in the interview, except possibly collectively at the end of her research. Lisa will provide you more information about the study and speak to you about consent if/when she contacts you.

Thank you for all you do for...! Stay safe, stay healthy and I look forward to seeing everyone in the office when this pandemic is over!

Sincerely,

*Descriptive information was removed

APPENDIX D
PARTICIPANT LETTER

Dear (Participant Name):

My name is Lisa D. Conley, and I am a doctoral student in the Workforce Education Department at the University of Georgia. I am conducting a study entitled: *Exploring Employee Perceptions of Personal Initiative and its Impact Career Achievement*. The primary purpose of this research is to explore how university employees perceive the concept of personal initiative as it relates to career achievement. *Personal initiative* refers to the actions an individual exhibits at work that are characterized by a self-starting nature, a proactive approach, and a persistence in overcoming problems occur in the pursuit of a goal.

You have been selected by your department head to participate in this study. I would like to interview you to gain insight about your perceptions.

Participation is completely voluntary. By completing the attached consent form, you are agreeing to participate in this study. Data will be coded to maintain confidentiality; thus, no data will be personally identified with you. Your name will not appear in any presentation or publication that results from this research. If you agree to participate, you may choose not to answer any given questions, and you may withdraw your consent and discontinue your participation at any time. There are no known risks to participating in the study.

If you have any questions, please don't hesitate to reach out to me. If you have any questions or concerns about the overall nature of this study, please contact me at Lisa Conley, Department of Career and Information Studies (Workforce Education), University of Georgia, Athens, GA 30602, 404-432-0766.

Thank you for participating in my research.

With appreciation,

Lisa Conley, M.Ed.
Workforce Education Doctoral Student
University of Georgia

APPENDIX E

EXPLORING EMPLOYEE PERCEPTIONS OF THE IMPACT OF PERSONAL INITIATIVE ON CAREER ACHIEVEMENT

You are being asked to take part in a research study. The information in this form will help you decide whether you want to participate in the study. Please contact the researcher below if any of this information is not clear or if you need additional information.

Principal Investigator: Lisa Conley, M.Ed.
Workforce Education
lconley3@uga.edu
404-432-0766

The primary purpose of this research is to explore how university employees perceive the concept of personal initiative as it relates to career achievement. *Personal initiative* refers to the actions an individual exhibits at work that are characterized by a self-starting nature, a proactive approach, and a persistence in overcoming problems occur in the pursuit of a goal.

If you agree to participate in my study, I will talk with you for 1.5 to 2 hours via interview and potentially a follow-up discussion. You do not have to participate in this study if you don't want to; it is your choice. You can change your mind at any time and there will be no penalty. You will decide the best time for your interview.

I will be careful to keep your information confidential, but there is always a small risk of unwanted or accidental disclosure. Our conversations will be recorded and transcribed only with your permission. You will have an opportunity to review a synopsis of the notes from your interview. Any notes, recordings, or transcriptions will be kept secure. The files will be encrypted, and password protected. You can decide whether you want your name used.

I give my consent to have discussions recorded: ____ (initial)

After I complete the interviews, I will remove anything that identifies you. The recordings will be destroyed after the transcription is complete. I may continue to use the de-identified transcripts and may share them with other researchers for future studies.

If you have questions about the study, please contact Lisa Conley at lconley3@uga.edu or 404-432-0766. If you have any complaints or questions about your rights as a research volunteer, contact the University of Georgia Institutional Review Board (IRB) at IRB@uga.edu or 706-542-3199.

If you agree to participate in this research study, please sign below:

Name of Researcher: Lisa D. Conley

Signature

Date:

Name of Participant:

Signature:

Date:

Please keep one copy and return the signed copy to the researcher.

APPENDIX F

INTERVIEW GUIDE

Research Question

How do employees perceive the concept of personal initiative?

Interview Question

How do you define the concept of personal initiative?

What are some advantages of exhibiting the characteristics of personal initiative?

What are some disadvantages of exhibiting the characteristics of personal initiative?

At what age do you feel you first experienced personal initiative?

How have employees experienced personal initiative in the workplace?

How have you seen personal initiative displayed at work?

Please provide an example of a time when something unanticipated went wrong at work and you needed to find a solution. How did you go about this? How long did it take you to develop a solution and act?

Tell me about a time when you went beyond your normal work duties.

During the last year, did you submit a suggestion to improve a work process?

Tell me about a time when you had a barrier at work that you had to overcome. How did you respond? What was the outcome?

Pretend for a moment that you have a work colleague who always does their work so sloppily that it creates additional work for you. What would you do?

How do employees perceive personal initiative has impacted their career achievement?

How do you define career achievement?

What has been your most significant career achievement to date? Did personal initiative play a role in this career achievement?

APPENDIX G

PARTICIPANT FOLLOW-UP FORM

EXPLORING EMPLOYEE PERCEPTIONS OF PERSONAL INITIATIVE: Participant Follow-up

Q1 Thank you once again for taking the time to participate in my research on Personal Initiative. The primary purpose of my research is to explore how university employees perceive the concept of personal initiative as it relates to career achievement. I have a few quick follow-up questions related to your interview.

Q2 Your Name:

Q3 Does the interview summary provided match your experience?

☐ Yes (1)

☐ No (2)

Q4 Would you like to add anything to your interview summary?

Q5 Please describe your racial identity:

- ☐ Asian (1)
- ☐ American Indian or Alaska Native (2)
- ☐ Black (3)
- ☐ Hispanic or Latinx (4)
- ☐ Multi-Racial (5)
- ☐ Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander (6)
- ☐ White (7)

Q6 To which gender do you most identify?

- ☐ Female (1)
- ☐ Male (2)
- ☐ Non-conforming (3)
- ☐ Transgender (4)
- ☐ Prefer not to answer (5)

Q7 Were you a **first-generation** college student? (*The formal definition of a first-generation college student is a student whose parent(s) did not complete a four-year college or university degree*).

☐ Yes (1)

☐ No (2)